CHENNAI - MONDAY - JUNE 1, 2026

₹10 • Pages 12 • Volume 33 • Number 151

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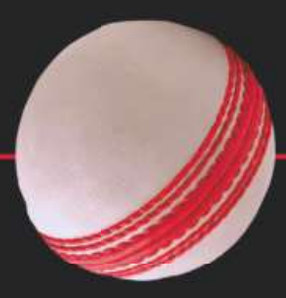
Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

Champions are crowned



And the fandom roars

on YouTube

YouTube is where sports come to life

Scan to know more

96% viewers watch cricket content on YouTube/Shorts
(higher than any other platform)

YouTube drives 2.3x incremental ROAS compared to social media

There's only one YouTube

Source: Kantar Media Compass: Survey Period- January 2026, TG- 18 yrs+ Urban NCCS ABCDE who watched cricket in the last one month (L1M). Sample All India SS = 1271 Gen Z SS = 573 Kantar Media Compass is a quarterly report based on a rolling sample of 87,000 consumers, measuring consumer media consumption across TV, print, and digital platforms. This data point is derived from a statistical fusion of call backs to 1271 users and the Kantar Media Compass, mapping a subset of cricket consumer behaviors onto a large-scale 360-degree media consumption framework.
2. Equity-to-Sales MMM Meta Analysis commissioned by Google, covering a 2-year measurement period of 20 CPG brands from across the 2021-2023 timeframe. "Long-term ROAS" is defined as impact of each marketing channel in driving brand equity & this brand equity's impact in driving sales, relative to the marketing channel's media spend.

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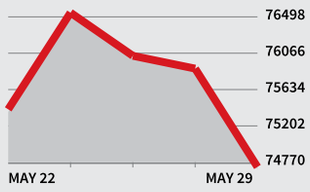
SENSEX 74775.74 (-639.61)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	23547.75	-171.55
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.10	-0.25
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.00	-0.69
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	155836.00	-1648
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	263350.00	-2650

LOGISTICS. **Mumbai port** is positioning itself as a specialised bulk, liquid and coastal shipping hub, says Chairperson M Angamuthu **p8**

QUANTUM. **Researchers at** IIT-Bombay engineer stapled peptides to aid in the fight against cancer **p7**

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Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

US may push India to lock in 18% tariff deal, offer Section 301 relief

DEAL DYNAMICS. It may seek deeper tariff cuts; India wants assured trade advantage

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

To clinch an early free trade deal with India, the US is likely to press New Delhi to accept a tariff package that locks in import levies on Indian goods around 18 per cent, as agreed to in the February framework deal. This will be backed by an assurance that more penalties won't be added after the ongoing Section 301 investigations against India conclude, sources said.

The high-level US trade team visiting India on June 1-4 to push negotiations to conclude the interim trade deal may also throw in a sweetener, guaranteeing further tariff reductions in the future aligned with the reduction in America's trade deficit with India, a source told *businessline*.

TRADE BARGAIN

- US wants India to accept capped tariffs of 18% that it had agreed to in the February framework
- It is likely to offer a guarantee that additional penalties under Section 301 will not be slapped
- Further tariff rollbacks for India, tied to the narrowing of the US trade deficit, may be proposed
- New Delhi wants assurance of tariff advantage over competitors such as Vietnam and Bangladesh
- Interim deal to focus on tariffs and non-tariff barriers, and will be expanded to include investments, IPR and government procurement

TARIFF LOCK-IN

"The US is keen to close the deal very soon, but it may take a while for its domestic tariff situation to settle down. That is why negotiators are likely to lock in a tariff rate around the 18 per cent level agreed to in February. This means additional penalties will not be imposed even if the Section 301 investigations result in an adverse verdict for India in the coming months," the source explained.

However, India remains uncertain about what tariffs competitors like Vietnam, Bangladesh, Indonesia or Cambodia will face, which determines how good its own deal is.

"Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal has stated that while India looks forward to sealing a bilateral pact, its primary objective remains securing a competitive advantage over other economies. If India agrees to a tariff level now, it needs to be sure it fares better than others," a second source said.

PACT FRAMEWORK

While this interim deal will focus mainly on tariffs and non-tariff barriers, the pact will subsequently expand to include elements like intellectual property, government procurement, investment protection, data flows, and customs and trade facilitation.

Under the February 2 framework, the US offered to lower reciprocal tariffs to 18 per cent from 25 per cent and remove the 25 per cent penalty for buying Russian oil, over and above the normal MFN tariffs. In return, India agreed to significantly reduce tariffs on US industrial and agricultural products. The US removed the oil tariffs, but reciprocal tariffs remained.

However, a landmark February 20 US Supreme Court judgment invalidated those reciprocal tariffs, leaving most countries facing a temporary 10 per cent global tariff above regular MFN rates.

The US' counter-argument to India's caution is that its competitors also face Section 301 investigations. "Every country realises Section 301 penalties could be huge. It will suit competitors to implement older trade deals clinched before the reciprocal tariffs were invalidated. The US is starting talks with many of them," the first source said.

India's trade surplus with the US declined in FY26 to $34.41 billion from $40.88 billion in FY25 as imports of American goods increased. However, the US remained India's largest export market in FY26 at $87.31 billion.

DoT spectrum move will enable vehicle-to-vehicle communication network

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

To address the staggering toll of over 1.8 lakh annual road deaths, India will soon roll out vehicle-to-vehicle (V2V) communication, enabling cars to exchange real-time safety data, to serve as a vital global tool for accident prevention.

The move follows plans by the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) to de-license the 5.875-5.925 GHz spectrum band, which can be used for V2V communications. Sources say the notification is expected shortly.

The objective is to provide alerts on potential hazards, such as sudden braking by a vehicle ahead, blind-spot risks, accidents or poor visibility, allowing drivers to react sooner and avoid collisions.

NOTIFICATION SOON

"DoT will soon notify on sufficient spectrum for this system and on how it should be utilised. Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) will ultimately decide on mandating its deployment," a senior DoT official told *businessline*.

The official added that the exact frequency range to be used would be determined in consultation with the MoRTH. Industry executives said V2V technology differs from the existing Advanced Driver Assistance Systems (ADAS).

EXTENDED REACH

V2V communication can complement ADAS by extending a vehicle's awareness beyond the line of sight of its sensors. The technology allows vehicles to receive alerts from other connected vehicles several hundred metres away.

Most newly launched vehicles come equipped with Level-2 ADAS capabilities. The effectiveness of V2V systems would increase if it is adopted across vehicle categories.

"The decision is a step in the right direction. Increased use of ADAS in sync with V2V technologies, along with improved road infra and road safety awareness amongst users, will improve road safety," Santosh Iyer, MD and CEO, Mercedes-Benz India, told *businessline*.

EPFO wage ceiling stays at ₹15,000 despite hike demands

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Despite demands from trade unions and experts, the government has retained ₹15,000 per month as the wage ceiling for Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) even under the Code on Social Security 2020, which is mandatory to determine eligibility and contribution caps for social security benefits to workers.

Government sources indicated that maintaining the current ₹15,000 wage ceiling is only temporary, with an increase expected down the line.

Also read **p2**

Vulnerabilities in evaluation portal, CBSE finally agrees

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Days after asserting that its online answer-sheet evaluation system had been "neither compromised nor suffered from the vulnerabilities" flagged by cybersecurity researchers, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Sunday acknowledged that weaknesses had been identified in the OnMark portal operated by its service provider and said they had been contained.

Also read **p2**

EV 2-W registrations up 58% in May, amid fuel supply woes

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

India's electric two-wheeler (E2W) market maintained its strong growth trajectory in May 2026, with total registrations rising 58 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to 1.64 lakh units from 1.04 lakh units in the same month last year, according to Vahan portal registration data as of 8.30 am on Sunday.

Read more on **p10**

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Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

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QUICKLY.

Suzlon to challenge SEBI's ₹29 cr penalty order in SAT

New Delhi: Suzlon Energy said it will move the Securities Appellate Tribunal (SAT) against a SEBI order imposing penalty of ₹28.95 crore on the company, its two promoters and ex-CFOs over alleged misrepresentation of financial statements. In a BSE filing, the company stated that the SEBI, through an order passed on May 29, 2026, set aside an earlier adjudication ruling on June 27, 2025. "The company will be filing an appeal before the SAT in respect of the SEBI order dated May 29, 2026," the renewable energy solutions provider said. PTI

Enumeration phase of SIR begins in 4 States

New Delhi: The enumeration phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Odisha, Mizoram, Sikkim and Manipur has started, the Election Commission said on Sunday. The poll authority had launched phase 3 of the SIR in 16 States and three Union Territories on May 14 in a staggered manner. PTI

IIP series with FY23 base year to be out today; 56 new item groups added

ALL ABOUT NUMBERS. Data for a particular month will be released on 28th day of the following month at 4 pm

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With the net addition of 56 new item groups, the Statistics Ministry will release the first monthly industrial growth data based on the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) under the new series on Monday.

The new series will have a base year of 2022-23 against 2011-12. This is the 10th revision of the base year of the all India IIP. The first IIP was prepared with the base year 1937, and thereafter the base year was revised successively to 1946, 1951, 1956, 1960, 1970, 1980-81, 1993-94, 2004-05 and 2011-12.

Meanwhile, despite the new look, data for a particular month will continue to be released on the 28th day of the following month at 4 pm.

ITEMS DROPPED

According to the Ministry, a total of 64 item groups have been dropped. These include kerosene, fluorescent tubes and CFLs, tubes for bicycle/tricycle/rickshaw tyres, tubes for LMV tyres, printing machinery and sewing machines, among others.

At the same time, 120 new item groups have been added. These include cards with magnetic stripe (debit cards and credit cards), CCTV cameras, articles of non-woven textiles, parts of aircraft and spacecraft, stents, and vaccines (other than veterinary).

Item baskets in new IIP

Item baskets	Item group in IIP 2011-12 series	Item group in IIP 2012-13 series
Mining & quarrying	1	3
Manufacturing	405	455
Electricity & gas supply	1	3
Water supply, sewerage & waste management	-	2
Total	407	463

Source: MoSPI

Electricity generation through renewable sources has been separately identified in the new IIP series.

With this, the total number of item groups in the new series will be 463 against 407 in the existing series. "An expanded item basket improves representativeness, captures diversification in industrial production, and reflects emerging industrial products and technologies," said the Ministry.

There is no change in the number of categories of use-based goods, and it will remain at six. These include primary goods (ores and minerals, fuels), capital goods (plant and machinery such as boilers, air and gas compressors, tractors, transformers, commercial vehicles and machinery such as textile machinery), intermediate goods (cotton yarn, plywood, steel tubes/pipes, fasteners, parts of automobiles), infrastructure/construction goods (paints, cement, cables, bricks and tiles, rail materials), consumer durable goods (pressure cookers, air conditioners, tyres, telephone and mobile instruments, TV sets, passenger cars, two-wheelers, gold jewellery) and consumer non-durable goods (edible oil, milk, milk powder, wheat flour, rice, biscuits/cookies, sugar, tea, coffee and medicines).

EXISTING SECTORS

The new series retains the existing sectors of mining, manufacturing and electricity. However, it expands the scope by including gas and water supply, sewerage and waste management activities, providing a broader and more accurate picture of industrial production. In the mining sector, the new series includes minor minerals and rare earth minerals, along with major minerals.

Talking about the preferred price deflator, the Ministry said that at present the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) is being used as the deflator for value-based items. After the release of the Output Producer Price Index (Output PPI), the same will be utilised after examining its stability. While the WPI captures the average movement of wholesale prices of goods and is primarily used as a GDP deflator, the Output PPI measures the average change over time in the selling prices received by domestic producers for their output.

CBSE admits that there are vulnerabilities in evaluation portal, more than week later

STUDENTS' UPROAR. Members of the National Students' Union of India during a protest against the CBSE

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Days after asserting that its online answer sheet evaluation system had been "neither compromised nor suffered from vulnerabilities", the CBSE on Sunday acknowledged that weaknesses had been identified in the OnMark portal operated by its service provider and said that they had been contained.

In a statement posted on X, the Board said: "We have been closely monitoring the vulnerabilities in the OnMark portal of our service provider that are being flagged in the public domain. An expert team of cybersecurity professionals has been deployed over the last few days from across various arms of the government and IITs to fortify these systems, including taking them over to a more secure setup. The identified vulnerabilities have been contained, and other exploitable weaknesses are being ruled out."

The Board also said: "We are grateful to all alert citizens and ethical hackers pointing out such weaknesses, and have gotten in touch with some of them directly. We request any others to reach out to our security teams at secy-cbse@nic.in for any further inputs."

However, 19-year-old ethical hacker Nisarga Adhikary, who has been publicly flagging the alleged security flaws in the system, disputed the CBSE's assertion that it had reached out to those raising concerns.

ETHICAL HACKER'S REPLY

"I mailed their security team hours ago," Adhikary told *businessline*. "I haven't heard back," he said, adding that "no one has contacted me".

He alleged that "they are still being dishonest and deceiving".

In his post on X on Sunday, Adhikary alleged that an AWS bucket containing 2026 answer sheets and question papers could be accessed without authorisation.

"CBSE people didn't configure their AWS bucket properly and now we can paginate & enumerate all their media, which has 2026 answer sheets and question papers. ListObjectsV2 works without any auth, and the bucket root is listable too — anyone on the internet can download any scanned booklet — across institutions. Multiple institutions are using the same bucket, insanely insecure. (sic)," he said.

CHECKS UNDERWAY

CBSE did not specifically address these latest allegations but maintained that the vulnerabilities identified in the system had been contained and that checks were underway to rule out other exploitable weaknesses.

EPFO wage ceiling frozen at ₹15,000 despite rising demands for hike

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Despite demands from trade unions and experts, the government has retained ₹15,000 per month as the wage ceiling for the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) even under the Code on Social Security 2020, which is mandatory to determine eligibility and contribution caps for social security benefits to workers.

Government sources indicated that maintaining the current ₹15,000 wage ceiling is only temporary, with an increase expected down the line.

For now, the threshold remains unchanged to avoid putting more compliance burden on businesses as employers already grappling with the rise in remuneration to employees following the implementation of the Code of Wages 2019.

The Code's new standardised definition of wages demands that basic pay and dearness allowance (DA) comprise at least 50 per cent of an employee's total remuneration — a shift scaling up overall wage costs, sources explained.

The Ministry of Labour and Employment issued the notification for retaining this limit, which has existed since September 1, 2014, when the government increased it from the earlier cap of ₹6,500 per month.

"In exercise of the powers conferred by clause (89) of section 2 of the Code on Social Security, 2020 (36 of 2020), the Central Government hereby notifies rupees fifteen thousand (₹15,000) per month as the wage ceiling for Chapter III of the said Code," read the notification issued on May 29.

Industry sources also stated that the government may have held onto the old wage ceiling structure for the EPFO because any increase would have impacted the government exchequer, already under stress owing to global supply chain disruptions because of the West Asia crisis.

BASIC WAGES

The Central government contributes 1.16 per cent of the basic wages up to the statutory ceiling of ₹15,000 toward the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS) while the 12 per cent contribution from both parties is calculated on the basic salary plus DA.

The EPFO has over 29 crore active members. The Supreme Court, hearing a PIL on a long-standing demand from labour unions and others, had asked the Ministry of Labour and Employment in the first week of January to decide on the revision of the wage ceiling, which remained unchanged for more than 11 years.

WAGE CEILINGS

The Ministry is of the view to revise and standardise the wage ceilings for both EPFO and the Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC). The ESIC wage ceiling threshold is ₹21,000.

It is proposed that both ceilings be revised and capped at a uniform monthly level of ₹25,000 to ₹30,000, as *businessline* had reported earlier.

Unions and economists have sought an increase in the wage ceiling, primarily because the old threshold does not reflect the changed economic reality of today. It does not address the years of inflation that have steadily eroded the purchasing power of employees.

Other than that, many States have already increased wage ceilings in their respective jurisdictions.

Karnataka Dy CM post is Congress' next big task

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

With DK Shivakumar scheduled to take oath as Chief Minister on June 3, attention has shifted to the composition of the new government, particularly whether the Congress will appoint multiple Deputy Chief Ministers to accommodate competing factions, caste groups and regional interests.

On the decision regarding Deputy Chief Ministers and Ministers, Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge said, "We have to wait and see; no proposal has come yet. After the proposal comes, how many ministers should be made, how many DCMs should be made or whether important chairmanships should be given along with this. That will be known after June 3."

He said the search for a new KPCC President is underway. The KPCC President's post is also expected to be keenly contested.

Fire at Hyundai Mobis plant near Chennai; no casualties reported

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

A major fire broke out on Sunday at the Hyundai Mobis facility near Hyundai Motor India's manufacturing plant at Irungattukottai on the outskirts of Chennai. No casualties were reported, though firefighting operations continued for several hours as the authorities worked to bring the blaze under control.

According to sources, the fire is believed to have originated in the soldering line of the assembly section before spreading rapidly through the plant. Multiple fire tenders were deployed to contain the flames, with firefighters continuing efforts even as this report went to print.

The facility supplies audio and electronic components to Hyundai Motor India and is located in close proximity to the automaker's manufacturing complex at Irungattukottai.

Company sources said it was too early to assess the extent of the damage.

Smoke billows after a fire broke out at the Hyundai Mobis factory ANI

Officials indicated that a detailed evaluation would be carried out once the fire was completely extinguished and the site declared safe for inspection. It will take a day or two to get full details, said sources.

The cause of the blaze is yet to be officially determined, and an investigation is expected to be launched to ascertain the circumstances leading to the incident.

The fire has raised concerns about disruptions to component supplies, although there was no immediate word on whether production at Hyundai Motor India's plant would be affected.

The company has not yet made an official statement.

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STATEMENT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026.

In Compliance with Regulation 52 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") the Board of Directors of the Shri Ram Finance Corporation Private Limited ("Company") at their meeting held on Saturday, 30th May, 2026 approved the Standalone Audited Financial Results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026. ("Results").
The results, along with the Auditor's Report (Standalone) by M/s. Agrawal & Bardiya, Statutory Auditor of the Company are available on the website of the Company at https://srfc.org.in/upload/disclosure/intimation_to_stock_exchange/Outcome %20of%20the %20Board% 20Meeting% 20held%20on%20May% 2030,%202026.pdf and on websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com. In compliance with Regulation 52(8) of the Listing Regulations, we hereby notify that the same can also be accessed by scanning the following Quick response (QR) code:

For Shri Ram Finance Corporation Private Limited
Sd/-
Gaurav Bhattar
Managing Director
DIN: 01248032

Place : Raipur
Date : May 30, 2026

KFC Kerala Financial Corporation

SARB(TVM) : VELLAYAMBALAM, THIRUVANANTHAPURAM–695033 Phone 0471-2737570,718, email: sarbsz@kfc.org, website:www.kfc.org

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE/MOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with provision to Rule 8 (6), 6(2) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable/movable property mortgaged/charged to Kerala Financial Corporation (herein after called the Secured Creditor), the constructive/physical possession of which has been taken on 27.04.2023 by the Authorised Officer of Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever there is" on 03.07.2026, for recovery of dues to Kerala Financial Corporation, Secured Creditor, from the below mentioned Borrowers/ Guarantors.

Sl No	Borrowers/ Guarantors	Description of immovable properties	Reserve Price(Rs.) EMD
1	(1)Late Sri. P Gopinatha Panicker *, Managing Partner, M/s PNM Hospital, (2)Dr. Sumam Gopinatha Panicker, (Partner), Killi, Kattakkada P.O.,Thiruvananthapuram 695572, * Late Sri. Gopinatha Panicker represented by his legal heirs (1) Dr. Divya Gopinath, Specialist Anesthesia, Medeor ICU, Medeor Hospital 24*7, Consulates, Area Sheikh Khalifa BinZayed Road, Bur Dubai, Close to Burjuman Metro Exit 1, (2) Dhanya Gopinath, Hridhyam, KRBRRA 67 A, K.R. Balachandran Road, Near Shiva temple, Cochin 682305 in addition to the existing Partners.	27.78 Ares (68.61 cent) of land in Re Sy No. 164/10 (old Re- Survey No.164/4-2,164/4-3, 164/4-4, 164/4-5) in Kulathummal Village, Neyyattinkara Taluk, Thiruvananthapuram District with five buildings having area of 68618 sq.ft located in left side of Trivandrum-Kattakkada Road, obtained as per Sale deed Nos.1819/1986 and 2546/1986 of Kattakkada SRO, together with the movable assets there in. **Boundaries** : North: Sy. No.788(part), South: Sy.No.725(part) & road East: Sy.No.786/3, West: Sy. No. 785 (*)(Details of movable properties are given below)	Reserve Price: Rs 10,57,34,000/- EMD: 52,87,000/- . The bid increment amount is Rs. 10,60,000 /-
2	Dr.Kiran Gopinath, (Partner),M/s PNM Hospital, Killi, Kattakkada P.O., Thiruvananthapuram 695572	93.70 Ares (231.53 cent) of land in Re-Survey No.150/11,165/1,165/2,165/4 of Kulathummal Village, Neyyattinkara Taluk, Thiruvananthapuram District as per Sale deed No.412/2003 and 157/2003 of Kattakkada SRO. Boundaries : North: Panchayat Road, South: Pond and property of Suma Gopinath East: Property of Manuel, Vijayan, Christudas,Sebastian, Francis and Chellappan. West: Property of Babu, George, Soman, Dasan Nadar and John	Reserve Price: Rs 2,08,37,000/- EMD :10,42,000/-. The bid increment amount is Rs. 2,10,000/-.
3	Late Sri. P Gopinatha Panicker*, Managing Partner, M/s PNM Hospital, Dr. Sumam Gopinatha Panicker,Killi, Kattakkada P.O., Thiruvananthapuram 695572,	27.27 Ares (67.35 cent) of land in Sy. 164/2 (New Re-Survey No.164/9,8) of Kulathummal Village, Neyyattinkara Taluk, Thiruvananthapuram District as per Sale deed No.914/93 and Sale Deed No 913/93 both of Ottasekharamangalam SRO. **Boundaries**: North: Property of Simon, Kunjachan, South: Pazhaya Road, East: Property of Sudhamani, West: Thodu.	Reserve Price: Rs 4,24,31,000/- EMD :21,22,000/- . The bid increment amount is Rs. 4,25,000/-.
4	Dr. Sumam Gopinatha Panicker, W/o late P Gopinatha Panicker, Killi, Kattakkada P.O., Thiruvananthapuram 695572.	18.86 Ares (46.58 cent) of land in Re-Survey No.164/11,164/12 of Kulathummal Village, Neyyattinkara Taluk, Thiruvananthapuram District as per Sale deed No.1706/1997 of Kattakkada SRO with building having an area of 25231 sq ft nursing college and quarters **Boundaries**: North: Property of Bahuleyan and public road, South: Property of Nelson East: Property of Thankappan, West: Property of Bahuleyan and Thodu.	Reserve Price: Rs 4,01,63,000/- EMD :20,10,000/-. The bid increment amount is Rs.4,00,000/-
		Description of movable properties: Hospital Equipments	

Encumbrances known to the Corporation: Sales tax, EPF.

Demand Notice Date 16.09.2019 & Due amount as on 01.05.2026 Rs.63,26,89,699/- (Sixty three crore twenty six lakh eighty nine thousand six hundred and ninety nine only).
Earnest Money Deposit shall be deposited on or before 02.07.2026, 5 PM. Details of Bank Account:10300200060004, IFSC Code: FDRL0001030 Name of Beneficiary: Kerala Financial Corporation, Name of Bank: Federal Bank, Name of Branch: Statue, Thiruvananthapuram.

STATUTORY 30 DAYS NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002

The e-auction will be conducted online through the Corporation's website(www.kfc.org/www.kfcauction.org) on 03.07.2026 between 12.15 PM to 12.45 PM with unlimited extensions of 5 minutes if bidding continues till the sale is concluded. For detailed terms and conditions on the sale please refer to the link "www.kfcauction.org" provided on the Corporation's Website (www.kfc.org) or contact the Branch Head, SARB, Thiruvananthapuram. (Tele No.0471-2737570) or Recovery Department, HO, Vellayambalam, Thiruvananthapuram, Ph: 0471- 2737531, during office hours on any working day.

Place: Thiruvananthapuram.
Date 01.06.2026

(Sd/-) Authorized Officer
Kerala Financial Corporation

Textile industry welcomes cotton import duty waiver, sees boost for exports

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The textile and apparel industry has welcomed the Centre's decision to temporarily exempt duties on cotton imports from June 1 to October 30, describing it as a timely measure that will improve raw material availability, ease cost pressures and enhance the competitiveness of Indian textile exports.

The government's move comes as the industry faces a significant cotton supply deficit. Industry bodies estimate that domestic cotton production during the current season will be around 290 lakh bales, while textile sector demand is expected to be between 330 lakh and 340 lakh bales, creating a shortfall of 50-70 lakh bales. The Coimbatore-based Southern India Mills' Association (SIMA) said it had been urging the government to remove the 11 per cent import duty on cotton. Cotton prices had surged from about ₹54,500 per candy (355 kg) to nearly ₹71,000 per candy over the past two months before showing signs of softening recently.

DUTY RELIEF

SIMA noted that similar duty exemptions were provided during April-October 2022 and August-December 2025 and said the latest decision would provide much-needed relief to the entire cotton textile value chain.

The Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPC) Chairman, A Sakthivel, said the decision would particularly benefit small and medium enterprises that have been grappling with rising cotton and yarn prices.

He urged spinning mills to pass on the benefits of lower cotton costs by rationalising yarn prices, thereby stabilising the value chain and enabling garment exporters to secure export orders more competitively.

The Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI) also welcomed the temporary removal of the duty, saying it would provide momentum to the MSME-dominated sector amid global uncertainty. CITI Chairman Ashwin Chandran said the import duty had placed Indian manufacturers at a disadvantage compared with competing Asian nations that enjoy duty-free access to cotton.

India-Oman zero duty deal in force from today

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) will formally come into force on Monday, providing immediate zero duty market access to Indian exports across 98 per cent tariff lines.

Strengthening economic and trade ties with Oman also holds great strategic importance for India as the country provides access to the Gulf countries bypassing the strife-stricken Strait of Hormuz.

Indian exporters across sectors such as textiles, automobiles and components, agricultural items, marine products, engineering goods, gems and jewellery and machinery — facing about 5 per cent tariffs — are expected to benefit significantly following duty elimination, per government estimates.

BIG GAINS

"Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal will preside over the India-Oman CEPA entry into force ceremony," according to the Commerce Department. Omani officials and top representatives are likely to join the ceremony virtually, an official said.

In FY26, India's exports to Oman were at $4.02 billion while it imported goods valued at $7.16 billion from the country.

An estimated $3.6 billion of India's exports are likely to gain immediate benefits, the government noted.

India has offered tariff liberalisation on 77.79 per cent of its total tariff lines to Oman, and the country stands to gain larger market access in energy and industrial inputs.

'Underlying momentum in industrial sector is intact'

CRUCIAL FACTOR. Continued policy support will remain instrumental in sustaining momentum and facilitating broad-based recovery, says FinMin report

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Ahead of the launch of the new series of industrial growth data, a Finance Ministry report has said that the underlying momentum in the industrial sector remains intact.

Further, it said that continued policy support will remain instrumental in sustaining this momentum.

"The continued resilience in construction-linked sectors, expanding manufacturing exports, sustained hiring intent, largescale investment commitments and emerging strength in sunrise sectors suggest that the underlying momentum in the industrial sector remains intact," said a report by the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA) of the Finance Ministry.

IMPETUS NEEDED. Core sector output crawled to a two-month high of 1.7 per cent in April, buoyed by steel, cement and electricity, despite contractions in five other sectors REUTERS

CORE SECTOR OUTPUT

This commentary arrives alongside a dual set of data showing subdued economic performance. India's core sector output crawled to a two-month high of 1.7 per cent in April, buoyed by steel, cement and electricity, despite contractions in five other sectors. Simultaneously, the Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) ticked up to 54.7 in April from 53.9 in March, yet still marking the second slowest growth in operating conditions in 46 months.

The report further said that continued policy support, whether through the recently approved Bhavya scheme or through targeted interventions under PLI, SPECS, promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects and the broader semiconductor mission, will "remain instrumental in sustaining this momentum and facilitating a more broad-based industrial recovery as external conditions gradually stabilise".

Highlighting the S&P Global's report on PMI Manufacturing about resilience in the manufacturing sector, the DEA report mentioned that the pipeline of investment commitments had remained robust.

"Toyota Motor Corporation is reportedly considering establishing additional vehicle assembly plants in Maharashtra, with planned investments estimated at around $1.9 billion, underscoring the longer-term recalibration underway in global automotive supply chains," it said.

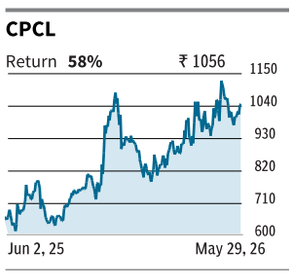
According to the DEA report, the electronics and semiconductor value chain is gathering momentum, with the ELCINA Electronics Manufacturing Cluster at Bhiwadi in Rajasthan attracting planned investments of over ₹1,200 crore from 20 companies, of which 11 are already operational and generating employment for over 2,700 people.

"The Sahasra Semiconductors ATMP/OSAT facility has become the first SME-led semiconductor packaging unit to commence commercial production in India," it said.

TODAY'S PICK.

Chennai Petroleum Corporation (₹1,056.50)

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau



The stock of Chennai Petroleum Corporation has been in an uptrend since March 2025. After hitting a one-year high of ₹1,159 last month, the price has moderated.

However, the broader bull trend remains positive and the price stays above both 21- and 50-day moving averages. Even if there is another downswing from the current level, it is unlikely to drag the stock below the crucial support at ₹950, where a trendline coincides. So, we expect the stock to resume the rally either from the current level or after another dip to ₹950.

In either case, the stock can rebound and appreciate to ₹1,300 over the medium-term. Buy now at ₹1,056 and accumulate at ₹970.

Stop-loss can be ₹880. On a rally to ₹1,150 and ₹1,250, raise the stop-loss to ₹950 and ₹1,180 respectively. Exit at ₹1,300.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

businessline.
Disclaimer: Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THG PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

Malabar Regional Co-operative Milk Producers' Union Ltd.
milma®
Head Office, Kunnamangalam, Kozhikode 673571, Kerala,
Ph: 0495-2805431, 2805415 Website: www.malabarmilma.com
Email: mrcmpu@malabarmilma.coop

MRCMPU/HO/MIS&S/11/2026/2 **E-TENDER NOTICE** 28/05/2026

E-Tenders are invited for the Annual Maintenance Contract for Computer Hardware & Networking items for three years from reputed parties. For details, visit www.malabarmilma.com. Tender Id:2026_KCMMF_853060_1.

Managing Director

VENLON ENTERPRISES LIMITED
POLYAL
Regd. Office & Works : 26 (P) & Plot No 2, Belavadi Industrial Area, Hunsur Road, Mysuru - 570 018 Phone : (0821) 2402530,
e-mail: gdrvenlon@gmail.com **CIN : L24231KA1983PLC015089**

STATEMENT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31ST MARCH 2026

(Rs. in Lakhs)

Particulars	Quarter Ended			For the Year ended	
	31-03-2026	31-12-2025	31-03-2025	31-03-2026	31-03-2025
	Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited
Total Income	252.52	137.37	315.75	829.01	1195.75
Net Profit for the period (before Tax, exceptional and /or extraordinary item)	(123.10)	(69.54)	(44.44)	(337.91)	(337.91)
Net Profit for the period before tax (after exceptional and /or extraordinary item)	(123.10)	(69.54)	(44.44)	(337.91)	(337.91)
Net Profit for the period after tax (after exceptional and /or extraordinary item)	(123.10)	(69.54)	(44.44)	(337.91)	(337.91)
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	(100.05)	23.71	(215.79)	(29.58)	(231.08)
Equity Share Capital	2612.12	2612.12	2612.12	2612.12	2612.12
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year.	-	-	-	-	(4620.27)
Earnings Per Share (of 5/- each)					
Basic:	(0.24)	(0.13)	(0.09)	(0.65)	(2.52)
Diluted:	(0.24)	(0.13)	(0.09)	(0.65)	(2.52)

The above is an extract of the detailed format of Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of Annual Financial Results are available on the website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com & Company's website https://venlonenterprises.co.in/ and can be accessed by using the QR Code provided below.

Place : Mysore
Date : 30.05.2026

By Order of the Board
C D Datwani (DIN:00355181)
Chairman & Managing Director

LAMBODHARA TEXTILES LIMITED
CIN L17111 TZ 1994 PLC 004929
Regd. Office : 3A, 3rd Floor, B Block, Pioneer Apartments
1075B, Avinashi Road, Coimbatore - 641 018, India Telephone: +91-422 2249038
Email & Investor Grievance ID : info@lambodharatextiles.com Web: www.lambodharatextiles.com

EXTRACT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED 31.03.2026

(Rs. in Lakhs)

S. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended			Year Ended	
		31.03.2026	31.12.2025	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
		Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	5,829.41	6,041.40	5,476.86	24,320.04	23,503.94
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	219.72	243.16	77.28	1,179.72	1,164.42
3	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and /or Extraordinary items)	219.72	243.16	77.28	1,179.72	1,164.42
4	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	312.92	240.42	21.51	1,100.48	682.49
5	Total Compehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	353.58	232.76	38.48	1,142.30	706.87
6	Equity Share Capital	518.88	518.88	518.88	518.88	518.88
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance sheet of the Previous Year	-	-	-	11,536.65	10,446.24
8	Earnings per equity share					
	Basic	3.02	2.32	0.21	10.60	6.58
	Diluted	3.02	2.32	0.21	10.60	6.58

Notes:
1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarter and year ended audited Financial results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the quarter and year ended audited Financial Results are available on the website of the Stock Exchange(s) (URL: www.nseindia.com & www.bseindia.com) and on the Company's website (URL: www.lambodharatextiles.com). The results can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below.
2. The above financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee at their Meeting on 30th May 2026 and approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on 30th May 2026. The results for the quarter and year ended 31st March 2026 and 31st March 2025 have been audited by the Statutory Auditors of the Company.
3. The results have been prepared in accordance with the Companies (Indian Accounting Standards) Rules, 2015 (Ind AS) prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013 and other recognised accounting practices and policies to the extent applicable.
4. Figures of the previous period/year have been regrouped and reclassified to confirm to the classification of current period/year, wherever necessary.

By Order of the Board
For Lambodhara Textiles Limited
sd/- Giulia Bosco
DIN : 01898020
Whole-Time Director

Place : Coimbatore
Date : 30.05.2026

KITEX
KITEX GARMENTS LIMITED
CIN: L18101KL1992PLC006528
Regd.Office : Bldg. No.VI/496, Kizhakkamabalam, Vilangu P O,Aluva, Kerala-683561 Web:www.kitexgarments.com, E-mail:sect@kitexgarments.com, Tel.0484 4142000, Fax: 0484 2680604

EXTRACT OF AUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026

Rupees in lakhs; except EPS and unless otherwise stated

Sl No	Particulars	Standalone				Consolidated			
		Quarter Ended		Year Ended		Quarter Ended		Year Ended	
		31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	31.03.2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from operations	12,554.12	31,560.22	63,660.93	1,01,941.42	20,036.88	30,485.37	71,928.15	1,00,134.57
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	1,378.13	5,548.00	6,100.72	20,674.94	(512.94)	4,768.37	(909.84)	18,954.22
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	1,378.13	5,548.00	7,850.72	20,674.94	(512.94)	4,768.37	840.16	18,954.22
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	962.20	3,961.25	5,689.98	15,295.33	(928.87)	3,181.62	(1,320.59)	13,574.60
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after tax)	1,050.05	3,926.95	5,781.98	15,259.90	(841.02)	3,147.32	(1,228.59)	13,539.17
6	Equity Share Capital	1,995.00	1,995.00	1,995.00	1,995.00	1,995.00	1,995.00	1,995.00	1,995.00
7	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the year	-	-	1,13,352.32	1,08,567.82	-	-	1,00,987.63	1,01,304.00
8	Earnings Per Share (of Rs.1/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations):-								
	Basic :	0.48	1.99	2.85	7.67	(0.20)	1.66	0.30	6.95
	Diluted:	0.48	1.99	2.85	7.67	(0.20)	1.66	0.30	6.95

Note:- 1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly and Annual Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. Kindly refer Note.6 of notes to Standalone Financial Result for the modified opinion of Statutory Auditor. The full format of the Quarterly and Annual Financial Results are available on the Stock Exchange websites- www.nseindia.com, www.bseindia.com and on the company's website:-www.kitexgarments.com.
2. The Board of Directors has proposed final dividend of Rs. 0.5 per Equity share of face value Rs 1 each in the adjourned meeting held on May 30, 2026, which will be paid subject to the approval of the shareholders.
3. The above audited financial results of the Company for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026 were reviewed and recommended by the Audit Committee at their meeting held on May 29, 2026 and approved by the Board of Directors at their adjournment meeting held on May 30, 2026. These results have been subjected to audit by Statutory Auditors.

By order of the Board
S/d
Sindhu Chandrasekharan
Whole-Time Director
DIN:06434415

Place : Kizhakkambalam
Date : May 30, 2026

TATA mutual fund

NOTICE

Unitholders are hereby informed about the declaration of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal under the Monthly Payout /Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option* of the following scheme. The record date for the same is 03 June, 2026.

Schemes - Plan / Option Name	Gross Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal amount per unit (Rs.) **	Face value per unit (Rs.)	NAV (Rs.) as on 27 May, 26
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Direct Plan*	0.81	10.00	98.2048
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Regular Plan*	0.81	10.00	81.6396

***(Monthly Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is not assured & is subject to the availability of distributable surplus.)**

Pursuant to payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal, the NAV of the scheme would fall to the extent of the payout & statutory levy (if applicable).

Unitholders kindly note that amounts are distributed out of investors capital (i.e., Equalisation Reserve), which is part of sale price of the unit that represents realised gains.

** Payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) at applicable rates and other statutory levies if any. Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to availability & adequacy of distributable surplus on the record date.

All unitholders holding units under the above-mentioned option of the scheme as at close of business hours, on the record date shall be eligible for Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal.

Considering the volatile nature of markets, the Trustees reserves the right to restrict the quantum of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal up to the per unit distributable surplus available on the record date in case of fall in the market.

Applicable for units held in non-demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders whose names appear in the Register of Unitholders under the Payout /Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in our records.

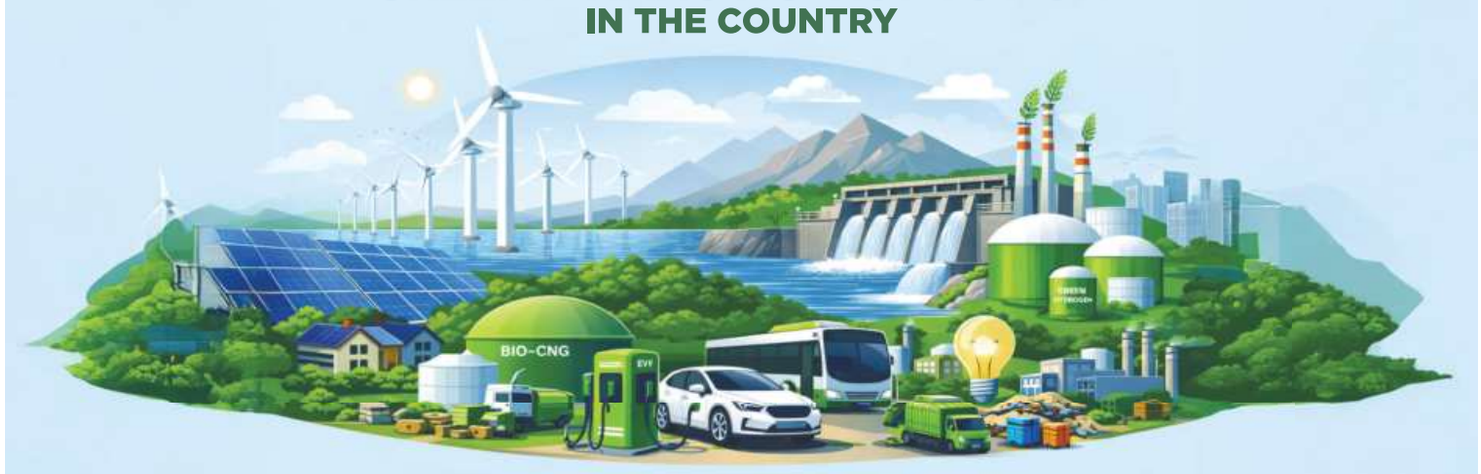
Applicable for units held in demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders/Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in Depository Participant(s) records.

Mutual Fund Investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

responsible for renewables

ENERGY FOR EVER
इरेडा IREDA
ONCE IREDA ALWAYS IREDA
(A Navratna CPSE)

THE LARGEST PURE-PLAY
GREEN FINANCING INSTITUTION
IN THE COUNTRY



*FY 2025-26 vs FY2024-25

PROFIT AFTER TAX* ₹1,873 crore Up By 10%
TOTAL INCOME FROM OPERATIONS* ₹8,337 crore Up By 23%
NET WORTH* ₹13,781 crore Up By 34%
LOAN BOOK* ₹93,069 crore Up By 22%

Extract of Audited Financial Results (Standalone and Consolidated) for the Quarter and Year ended 31 March 2026

(₹ in Crores)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone					Consolidated				
		Quarter ended			Year ended		Quarter ended			Year ended	
		31-Mar-26	31-Dec-25	31-Mar-25	31-Mar-26	31-Mar-25	31-Mar-26	31-Dec-25	31-Mar-25	31-Mar-26	31-Mar-25
		(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)	(Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations	2,180.90	2,139.60	1,914.73	8,337.48	6,754.78	2,181.28	2,139.92	1,915.64	8,338.89	6,755.69
2.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	619.26	716.95	629.98	2,336.92	2,103.80	619.14	717.20	629.73	2,337.58	2,103.54
3.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	619.26	716.95	629.98	2,336.92	2,103.80	619.14	717.20	629.73	2,337.58	2,103.54
4.	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	492.75	584.91	501.79	1,873.34	1,698.60	492.62	585.16	501.55	1,874.00	1,698.34
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	577.74	536.35	487.19	1,993.46	1,766.83	579.20	536.98	487.59	1,997.15	1,767.21
6.	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face Value of ₹10/- each)	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,687.76	2,809.23	2,687.76	2,809.23	2,809.23	2,687.76	2,809.23	2,687.76
7.	Other Equity	10,972.12	10,727.45	7,578.40	10,972.12	7,578.40	10,976.19	10,730.04	7,578.78	10,976.19	7,578.78
8.	Securities Premium Account (net)	2,737.56	2,737.56	864.26	2,737.56	864.26					
9.	Net Worth	13,781.35	13,536.68	10,266.16	13,781.35	10,266.16					
10.	Paid-up Debt Capital/Outstanding Debt	77,845.63	73,192.10	64,740.31	77,845.63	64,740.31					
11.	Debt Equity Ratio	5.65	5.41	6.31	5.65	6.31					
12.	Earnings Per Share (of ₹10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)										
	A. Basic:	1.76	2.09	1.87	6.73	6.32	1.76	2.09	1.87	6.73	6.32
	B. Diluted:	1.76	2.09	1.87	6.73	6.32	1.76	2.09	1.87	6.73	6.32
13.	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	439.01	439.01	-	439.01	-	439.01	439.01	-	439.01

Notes:
a) The above results have been approved by the Board of Directors in its meeting held on 29 May 2026 and have been audited by the Joint Statutory Auditors of the Company.
b) The above is an extract of the detailed format of quarterly and year ended financial results filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 & 52 of the SEBI LODR Regulations. The full format of the said financial results are available on the website of the Company www.ireda.in/financial-results and on the websites of Stock Exchanges www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com.
c) For the other line items referred in Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI LODR Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to Stock Exchanges and can be accessed at www.bseindia.com & www.nseindia.com, respectively.
d) The Board of Directors in its meeting held on May 29 2026, recommended final dividend of ₹0.75/- per equity share (on face value of ₹10/- each) for the financial year 2025-26, subject to approval of Shareholders in the ensuing Annual General Meeting. The total dividend for the financial year is ₹1.35/-per equity share (on face value of ₹10/- each) including interim dividend of ₹0.60 per share.

For and on Behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Pradip Kumar Das
Chairman & Managing Director
DIN No.: 07448576

Date: 29.05.2026
Place: New Delhi

INDIAN RENEWABLE ENERGY DEVELOPMENT AGENCY LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Registered Office: 1st Floor, Core-4A, East Court, India Habitat Centre, Lodhi Road, New Delhi- 110003, **Tel:** 011-24682206-19, **Fax:** 011-24682202
Corporate Office: 3rd Floor, August Kranti Bhawan, Bhikaiji Cama Place, New Delhi- 110066, **Tel:** 011-26717400- 12, **Fax:** 011-26717416
Business Centre: NBCC Office Complex, Office Block No. II, Plate B, 7th Floor, East Kidwai Nagar, New Delhi- 110023, **Tel:** 011-24347729-99
Website: www.ireda.in | **CIN:** L65100DL1987GOI027265

SCAN THE QR CODE TO VIEW THE AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS

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CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - JUNE 1 - 2026

the hindu businessline.
MONDAY - JUNE 1, 2026

Stay the course

MPC should retain status quo in difficult times

There has been an animated debate on whether the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) should hike the policy repo rate later this week. Those who feel rates should be hiked have cited incipient inflation and the depreciating rupee as reasons. Here, it is important to cite a monetary policy maxim — that using interest rates to target both domestic and external parameters is generally considered to be a bad idea.

The Reserve Bank of India has a sophisticated toolkit, quite apart from interest rates, to intervene in both domestic liquidity and forex markets — which ensures that neither is roiled in the process. The use of interest rate to manage the rupee can send contrary confidence signals. Therefore, interest rate moves should be pegged more to domestic conditions. All things considered, a status quo this time seems the best course of action. These are exceptional, war-torn times. Like the rest of the world, India is faced with a difficult year ahead. Global commodity, currency and financial markets are very volatile, as a result of which India's growth inflation-mix has altered rapidly since the April monetary policy. Growth prospects are likely to have receded by about 30 basis points for FY27 since April, from 6.9 per cent to 6.6 per cent, on supply bottlenecks.

Inflation is likely to be closer to 5 per cent in FY27, up 40 basis points — with crude prices assumed to be at an average $95 a barrel. RBI, an inflation-targeting central bank, is up against a dual growth and inflation challenge. With wholesale price inflation at a 42-month high of 8.3 per cent in April, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said that inflation could get generalised — despite retail inflation being at 3.5 per cent in April, which is within the 2-6 per cent target. In that event, RBI Governor has indicated future hikes. For now, there is breathing space, precisely because the mandate is one of 'flexible' inflation targeting, which allows growth concerns a look-in. There is a window to allow growth, given the prospect of a weak monsoon.

The RBI seems to be cognisant of this fact. The system has been in liquidity surplus, despite heavy interventions in the forex market in recent days. The way forward should be to keep the policy rate at 5.25 per cent at least till the real interest rate does not slip deep into negative, and till such time address inflation through subtle liquidity management, which could include 'operation twist' which flattens the yield curve. Another option before the MPC is to raise the marginal standing facility rate — the emergency overnight lending window for banks, which is rarely used. If liquidity can be subtly managed without changing the policy rate, the rupee can be dealt with without creating a flutter. Buy-sell rupee-dollar swaps can arrest depreciation such that the liquidity or forex impact is deferred. Finally, if headline inflation were to spin out of control, there is always the option of doing an off-cycle rate hike. So, it is best to stay the course now.

OTHER VOICES.

ALL THE NEWS WITHOUT FEAR OR FAVOR
The Japan Times

Long overdue, Japan updates its intelligence infrastructure

Long neglected, but critical to the success of Japan's defense modernization effort, is reform of the national intelligence infrastructure. The government of Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is taking steps to improve that capability with passage of the National Intelligence Council Law. Opposition to the measure has been limited; to their credit, opposition parties understand the importance of this legislation and are focusing on genuine issues, not political grandstanding. Chief among them are safeguards to protect individual rights. They must be protected as intelligence reform proceeds. Japan has debated for over four decades the need to update its intelligence infrastructure. In the 1980s, the government of then-Prime Minister Yasuhiro Nakasone put forward legislation that would prohibit collection of "state secrets" and sending that information to foreign countries. (TOKYO, MAY 29)

GULF NEWS

Heart disease prevention may be entering a new era

The latest National Health and Nutrition Survey found that more than half of adults in the UAE have high cholesterol. Many adults also live with high blood pressure, obesity, and low levels of physical activity. These problems often come together. Over time, they increase the risk of heart attacks and strokes. This is why new research from the pharmaceutical company Eli Lilly is worth watching closely. The company recently announced promising early results for VERVE-102, an experimental treatment designed to lower LDL cholesterol, often called "bad cholesterol." Unlike traditional medicines, this is not a daily pill. It is a one-time treatment that aims to make a small edit in the liver, targeting the responsible gene. (DUBAI, MAY 31)

LINE & LENGTH.

TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

The power of successful myths

It's a myth that elections are lost because of reforms and inflation. Chances are that people only vote for change when they are thoroughly bored with a government

Once again, India's economic non-performance, or rather industrial non-performance, has become a subject of intense debate. Specifically, people talk of the need for reform without saying which market they are talking about — labour, product or financial. Nor do they seem to know that much of what is regarded as reform has already been done since 1993. Slowly, yes but done.

Truth be told, there is a great deal of ignorance in the public discourse on the economy. As Kaushik Basu once famously wrote, while no one says a word about aircraft design, everyone comments on economic policy design and implementation.

So what's the reason for our slow pace of industrialisation which has locked us out of the world economy and its supply chains? And what little there is, is so heavily dependent on imports.

And this leads to a more uncomfortable question: Can a country have rapid industrialisation without an undemocratic supporting structure? A structure that allows high returns to capital via massive state sponsored financial support and low returns to labour via complicity in keeping wages down?

We all know the answer and it's a big no. It doesn't matter whether it is the US and Europe in the 170 years from 1760 to 1930 or East Asia from 1960 to 1990 or China since 1980. The story is the same. Very little or no democracy and high growth rates.

We all also know that the fully democratic Indian political system sees a direct and negative connection between economic reforms and losing elections. The truth, however, is that this is a myth fostered by the Left in the wake of the 1996 defeat of the Congress. The reform of removing industrial licensing went straight up the Left's nostrils because it reduced the bargaining power of its trade unions.

REFORMS OR INFLATION

But the fact is that the Narasimha Rao government didn't actually do all that much reform in the real sector, certainly not enough to have lost an election. True, it abolished industrial licensing but that created more jobs and incomes. So why was it voted out?

Few know this but nearly all of the reforms between 1992 and 2015 have been in the financial sector. These had no political impact. In fact, they brought down interest rates and helped generate a massive housing and insurance finance boom. So why were elections lost?

The product markets had been in need of some regulatory tweaking especially on compliances. But, for completely unfathomable reasons, as many studies have shown, the governments of Rao, Vajpayee and Manmohan Singh kept dragging their feet. The Modi government has tried but not hard enough.

> **The fully democratic Indian political system sees a direct and negative** connection between economic reforms and losing elections. The truth, however, is that this is a myth

Some say it was inflation that did that government in and this, too, is a widely held political belief. But the causation is weak. Look at the experience.

In 1995 inflation was at about 10 per cent, which is high. But in 2009, too, it was at 10 per cent and, in spite of that, the Congress came back to power with 64 more seats than in 2004. In contrast, in 2013 the inflation rate was nearly 11 per cent and the Congress got decimated with just 44 seats. You can find a similar weak correlation or causation in the 1980s also.

The simple fact is that we don't know how people vote and whether they vote rationally. Chances are that people only vote for change when they are thoroughly bored with a government.

WHICH IS IT THEN?

So if it's not reforms or inflation that lose governments elections, what's the problem? Why are all political parties so scared of reforms when they don't do any electoral damage or inflation which is rarely a reason for losing a general election?

A former finance minister once told me that this is the power of successful myths. They become the received wisdom because they seem so very highly likely.

In economics this is known as the 'post hoc, ergo propter hoc' problem or fallacy. It means "After this, therefore because of this". Causation is attributed, not proved.

This also happens to be the basis of all superstition where, for example, the movement and position of distant planets can affect outcomes of an individual human — but never an animal or a tree or a river.

To a large extent, the political scrum is a combination of mythology and superstition that's used to fool the electorate. The problem in India is that the political parties since 1996 have fooled themselves more than the electorate.

How to make green hydrogen viable in industry

In a situation of fuel crisis, policies that create long-term demand for green hydrogen and lower its delivered cost are vital

Amarendu Nandy
Goutam Dalapati

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to use petrol and diesel sparingly has brought India's energy vulnerability back into focus. India's response, however, cannot stop at short-term restraint by households alone. Imported fossil energy is built into India's industrial economy — in fertilizers, refineries, ammonia and other energy-intensive production chains. Therefore, any serious response must reduce fossil-fuel dependence where it is embedded in production.

In this regard, the National Green Hydrogen Mission (NGHM) needs to be reviewed through a sharper energy-security lens. The Mission's 2030 target of 5 million tonnes (mt) of annual green hydrogen capacity is ambitious, but to create resilience, the immediate task must be to convert existing demand for grey hydrogen and ammonia into green, contract-backed demand that firms can finance and use at scale. For accelerated adoption, several policy imperatives follow.

First, green hydrogen adoption must be expedited in core industries like fertilizers and refineries, where existing grey hydrogen and ammonia use can be converted into durable and bankable green demand. SECI's 10-year agreements to supply 7,24,000 tonnes of green ammonia annually to 13 fertilizer units, with estimated forex savings of about $2.5 billion over a decade, and refinery-linked green hydrogen projects covering 30,000 tonnes per annum, are useful steps. Their real value lies in the demand signal. India's hydrogen policy will acquire substance only when existing industrial demand becomes credible long-term demand for green hydrogen, reducing fossil-import dependence where it is embedded in production.

FINAL DELIVERED COST

Second, hydrogen economics must be judged by delivered cost, not production cost alone. Cheap production can still become uncompetitive once transport, storage, conversion losses and purification are added. If delivered costs remain high, green hydrogen will not work as an import-substitution strategy. Evidence from advanced hydrogen markets suggests that midstream and end-use infrastructure can account for 70-85 per cent of the final delivered cost, even when production costs are only $2-3 per kg.

India should therefore avoid building the early market only around large coastal hubs and long-distance supply chains. Such hubs matter for exports and large industrial users, but they cannot by themselves serve the dispersed domestic industries whose fossil dependence the Mission must reduce.

Third, hydrogen adoption should not be built only around large, centralised projects. Many small and mid-sized industrial users need reliable, high-quality hydrogen in modest quantities, close to the point of use. For them, modular, on-site or near-site production may be more economical than sourcing from distant hubs. Policy should therefore focus on building domestic competence in modular electrolysers, high-purity hydrogen systems and application-specific engineering. There are wider opportunities in specialty chemicals, advanced materials, and, over time, in derivatives such as green ammonia and synthetic fuels. A hydrogen ecosystem built around only a few large public-sector applications will not create the engineering firms, component suppliers and specialised manufacturers needed for a durable market.

WAY TO GO. Smaller hubs for the production for green hydrogen GETTY IMAGES

Fourth, electrolyser policy must support both scale and distributed use. The NGHM's ₹4,440 crore incentive scheme has awarded 15 companies domestic manufacturing capacity of 3,000 MW per annum, but its design remains tilted towards larger manufacturers. The main bidding buckets had 100 MW thresholds, though one smaller bucket allowed bids from 10 MW. Since electrolysers form a large share of green hydrogen costs, scale and efficiency matter. But if the mission is to reduce fossil dependence across industry, it must also support modular applications. A calibrated SME window for 10 kW to 2 MW stacks could enable small-scale, near-site electrolysis for dispersed industrial users and MSMEs that cannot viably connect to coastal hubs. Studies suggest such systems can match or improve large-hub break-even periods once transport and grid-access costs are included, especially with targeted capital subsidies of 20-30 per cent.

Finally, a hydrogen policy cannot be separated from power-sector reform. If green hydrogen is to reduce fossil-import dependence inside industry, electrolysers must run on renewable power that is cheap, reliable and dispatchable. India has built a strong baseline, surpassing 50 per cent non-fossil installed capacity ahead of its 2030 National Determined Contribution timeline. However, if grid transmission bottlenecks, storage gaps, and open-access frictions persist, domestic hydrogen will remain too expensive to compete.

The Mission will count only when green hydrogen becomes commercially usable in ordinary industrial settings.

Nandy is Associate Professor in the Economics & Public Policy Area at IIM Ranchi, and Dalapati is Chief Technology Officer at Hydrogen Innovation Pte. Ltd. Views are personal

BELOW THE LINE

Headcount harvest

The talking point at the recent National Kharif Conference seemed to be more about attendance figures than paddy or pulses. A Joint Secretary had confidently announced that 19 State agriculture ministers had turned up. Soon after, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan welcomed ministers from 17 States in his inaugural remarks. Then came a late entrant from Uttarakhand, nudging the tally to 18, and the count appeared to include West Bengal's "potential" agriculture minister. By lunchtime, Chouhan told reporters that 20 ministers had attended. The next day, an official press release raised the figure to 22.

The arithmetic has left many in the media perplexed, particularly because, on the eve of the conference, Chouhan had declared that agriculture ministers who skipped the event did not deserve to remain ministers. One wag in the bureaucracy now jokes that, given enough time, the attendance figure may yet climb to 31, plus the ministers from three Union Territories.

Avoiding media gaze

The Supreme Court's decision to uphold the retrospective application of the hefty 28 per cent GST levy on online gaming companies produced a predictable reaction among industry players — staying away from the limelight and avoiding the media gaze. At Mumbai Tech Week, sessions featuring Dream11 co-founder Harsh Jain and Nazara Technologies chief Nitish Mittersain were quietly dropped a day before the event. Sources said the two leaders did not want to face media questions just yet. Legal experts say online gaming companies will struggle to absorb the blow and some may be even forced to fold up. This seems to be one gamble that may have gone wrong — for now.

Race for next Army chief

With new Chief of Defence Staff Gen NS Raja Subramani and Navy Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan assuming charge on Sunday, buzz has now shifted to Indian Army which will get a new chief next month. Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth is believed to be a frontrunner, to replace General Upendra Dwivedi as the next Army Staff. Others in the race, include Lt Gen Pushpendra Singh and Lt Gen Pratik Sharma.

Meanwhile, Indian Air Force (IAF) Chief, Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh, is also scheduled to retire in October this year.

Telangana's Unified Card

If Andhra Pradesh is talking AI, can Telangana be far behind. Advocating "AI in governance", Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy has ordered creation of a one-stop multi-purpose Unified Card, with details of all welfare benefits and other government touch-points across departments.

This AI-based system is meant for dynamic tracking of 360-degree beneficiary data.

Unified Card would be designed in such a way that it carries details of every individual's benefit drawn across schemes and government departments.

Reddy suggested creating a state-level unique identity number on the lines of Aadhaar. And that the data from the Socio-Economic, Education, Employment, Political and Caste (SEEEPC) Survey should also be merged with the Unified Card profile. While Reddy's intent may be good, the core of any such programme is resources. Does Telangana have the funds, asked a critic. **Our Bureaus**

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A map for investing

An empathetic lens on women's financial challenges

BOOK REVIEW.

Gayathri G

At the heart of this deeply insightful book lies a powerful, almost paradoxical truth: Indian women are celebrated as disciplined savers, yet many fall short when it comes to building sustainable wealth. The author begins by unpacking this contradiction, drawing a sharp distinction between saving and investing — two terms often used interchangeably but fundamentally different in purpose and outcome. Saving preserves money; investing grows it. This simple yet transformative shift in mindset sets the tone for the rest of the book.

This book succeeds in making personal finance less intimidating and more relatable by blending financial concepts with everyday Indian realities.

One of its strongest features is the author's ability to simplify complex ideas through familiar analogies. Asset allocation, for instance, is compared to an Indian *thali* — balanced, diverse and incomplete without the right mix of ingredients.

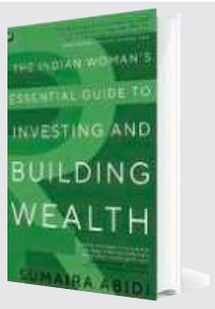
Similarly, compounding is introduced as the "eighth wonder of the world", echoing Einstein's famous quote, while illustrating how equities and mutual funds can create long-term multiplier effects unlike low-risk, low-return traditional instruments such as fixed deposits.

More advanced financial concepts such as the Sharpe ratio and Alpha are introduced, helping readers evaluate risk-adjusted returns and fund performance. Equally important is the guidance on portfolio rebalancing, emphasising that investment strategies should evolve with age, life stage, and market conditions. Goal setting is presented as the anchor of all financial planning — whether it's retirement, children's education, or financial independence.

The author also examines the role of gold, while offering stability and acting as a hedge, it cannot always match the wealth-creation potential of equities. The author reinforces the importance of understanding how mutual fund redemptions can disrupt compounding, using clear illustrations to show the cost of premature withdrawals.

Practical advice abounds: building a contingency fund, securing adequate insurance (preferably term plans rather than investment-linked policies), and navigating India's taxation system. The inclusion of updated tax slabs (as of March 1, 2026) in tabular form is especially useful, making what is often a daunting subject more approachable.

Debt management is another key theme. The author distinguishes between "good" debt (like home loans) and potentially harmful liabilities such as personal loans.



Title: The Indian Woman's Guide to Investing and Building Wealth
Author: Sumaira Abidi
Publisher: Aleph Book Company
Price: ₹699

WOMEN'S CHALLENGES

What truly sets this book apart is its empathetic lens on the unique financial challenges faced by women. From tackling gender stereotypes in money matters to addressing the realities of single women, single mothers, widows, and women on career breaks, the book offers nuanced, scenario-based guidance. Practical advice — such as investing divorce settlements wisely in strategies like Systematic Withdrawal Plans (SWPs), updating nominee details under inheritance laws, or continuously upskilling during mid-career breaks — gives the book both relevance and depth.

The discussion on career breaks is particularly relevant in today's context. The author strongly advocates for continuous upskilling, especially in fast-evolving fields like IT, finance, and healthcare.

The author describes the book as both a mirror and a map. It is filled with real-life anecdotes that make the lessons tangible and relatable. While the book is primarily aimed at women, men, too, would benefit from reading it — not only to improve their own financial literacy but to ensure that the women in their lives are empowered and prepared for uncertainties.

A turnaround tale well told

A fascinating story of how Tata Elxsi, facing near bankruptcy, became one of the highest valued Tata companies globally

BOOK REVIEW.

Vinay Kamath

If CEOs need to have lots of passion, perseverance and a streak of doggedness, S Devarajan, a former managing director of Tata Elxsi, displays a lot of these qualities as he describes incidents at various junctures in his career in his book, *Designed to Win, The Tata Elxsi Story*.

In the book he writes about this Tata company's turnaround journey from a loss-making entity to one with a record high valuation. A major in AR/VR, visual simulation, medical imaging and product styling and design, now an immensely profitable company, it was FC Kohli, the founder of the Indian software industry and a former Chairman of TCS, who roped in Devarajan from a sales career at HCL as a general manager and eventually promoted him to the MD's post to spearhead a revival. Devarajan also writes about encounters with Kohli in a separate chapter, which make for fascinating reading.

The book's prologue is quite engrossing, and gives an insight into Devarajan's mental toughness. As a 25-year-old sales engineer with HCL in 1981, he was to conclude a large deal with a paper mill in Kurnool, across the banks of the Tungabhadra river. Reaching there one morning, he found the ferry had left for the day.

The only way across was in a coracle, which, made from reed, looks like a large saucepan. Sitting at the centre of it, with water leaking onto his polished leather shoes and crisply ironed trousers, the coracle, often spinning about in the mighty river, got him safely to the other side.

The CFO, with whom he had a meeting, was quite aghast how he got across and took him to meet the company MD, who was quite impressed with his perseverance. The MD told the CFO to issue a purchase order and a cheque for an advance.

As he writes in the book, "Crossing the Tungabhadra wasn't just about reaching the other side, it was about embracing the challenge...taking a leap of faith, no matter how daunting, which leads to opportunities that redefine our paths."

This incident had an interesting denouement. In 1998 as CEO of Tata Elxsi, a sales engineer requested Devarajan to have breakfast with his father-in-law, who, it turned out was the MD of that paper mill, now retired. Remembering the name, the retired gentleman was curious to ascertain if he was the same person.

NOCTURNAL DEAL MAKING

Fast forward to February 1999. Tata Elxsi needed to secure a major deal before the financial year end with Shyam Ramanna's Crest Communications, a major animation studio based in Mumbai. The only issue was Ramanna, son of the famous nuclear scientist, Raja Ramanna, worked only through nights and rested by day. Devarajan boarded a flight at 6.30 p.m. from Bengaluru, worked through the night with Shyam and his wife Seema, who handled the finances.

There was a lot of drama with the deal being reworked multiple times, but in the end Devarajan and his team had a purchase order in hand at 4 a.m. and he managed to take the 6.30 a.m. flight to Bengaluru. Again, his doggedness was on display; it was early days of Tata Elxsi's journey on the profitability route and Devarajan needed that order to boost the numbers. And, he wasn't taking no for an answer!

In 1995, Devarajan, still the GM of the company — he would be made the MD the following year when its MD quit — had a face-off with Ratan Tata, a situation where he had to stick to his guns. Tata Elxsi had already had its IPO earlier. The company still had accumulated losses to clear. Tata Elxsi executives proposed a rights issue to shore up cash reserves. Ratan Tata's response was immediate: "Who would invest more in a loss-making company?" But, they were confident and told Tata so.

Title: Designed to Win: The Tata Elxsi Story
Author: S Devarajan
Publisher: Penguin Business
Price: ₹699

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Devarajan (Dev) founded Transmation Consulting to give technology companies a platform to accelerate and transform their business strategies. Previously he was the Managing Director of Tata Elxsi, and Managing Director of Cisco Systems in India

NOMENCLATURE GOOGLY

Meanwhile, Tata threw another bombshell — to change the name Elxsi as that entity was no longer in existence. As Devarajan recalls: 'We were in the thick of non-performance. We had borrowed enough money from Tata Industries, debts were accumulating. I was keen that we make do with self-generated funds and not borrow anymore." The CFO threw another googly — changing the name would entail an EGM and sending letters to shareholders which would cost ₹5 lakh, a sum the company did not want to spend. When Devarajan told Tata this, the latter was flummoxed and said it could borrow the sum from Tata Industries, but Devarajan dug his heels in and said the company did not want to borrow any more. Ultimately, Tata respected the decision and Tata Elxsi it remained.

Devarajan weaves in a lot of anecdotes and descriptive stories which add to the readability of the book. The author brings in a lot of drama into his narration which adds to the pace of the book, except where he delves into describing the tech which Tata Elxsi was involved in which makes it a bit academic and slows it down. But that bit is only a short spurt before the author resumes his story-telling narrative style.

Especially interesting is a chapter on FC Kohli, where Devarajan writes about his vision, his eccentricities, his love for jazz, his curt and strict demeanour, which conceals warmth and affection.

While Devarajan moved on from Tata Elxsi in 2001 to head Cisco Systems and later be on his own, the company he headed went on to scale greater heights and is now a profitable, niche tech company in the Tata group's fold. A tale well told.

The reviewer is a senior journalist

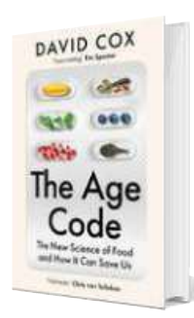
NEW READS.

Title: Air Warriors 2

Author: Arijit Ghosh

Publisher: Penguin Random House

The book relays untold stories of feats of bravery, of boldness, of fearlessness in the face of peril set against the backdrop of the day-to-day operations of the Indian Air Force



Title: The Age Code: The New Science of Food and How It Can Save Us

Author: David Cox

Publisher: Fourth Estate

What if the food you eat could rewind your biological clock? This book gives a fascinating and insightful account of such potential

Title: Master of Lies: How Anthony Blunt's Treachery Changed Our World

Author: Piers Blofeld

Publisher: Quercus

In a brilliant feat of literary detective work the book tells the extraordinary untold story of Anthony Blunt's life as a spy

thehindu businessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

June 1, 2006

Farm sector propels GDP growth to 8.4%

The Government on Wednesday put out revised figures of economic growth during 2005 06, showing that the agriculture sector had actually grown by 3.9 per cent against the earlier estimate of 2.3 per cent. On the other hand, the manufacturing sector growth was 9 per cent and not 9.4 as was estimated in February this year when the advance estimates were released.

We will continue to attract FIIs: Chidambaram

The Finance Minister, Mr P Chidambaram, today expressed confidence that the country would continue to attract foreign institutional investors' capital even as he asserted that temporary net selling by such investors does not mean that there was outflow of foreign capital.

Immelt meets Lalu

The GE Chief Executive Officer, Mr Jeffrey R. Immelt, on Wednesday met the Union Minister for Railways, Mr Lalu Prasad , the National Security Adviser, Mr M.K. Narayanan, and the Prime Minister's Principal Scientific Adviser, Mr R. Chidambaram, on the Delhi leg of his two-day India tour. GE made enquiries about Railways' acquisition plans in the areas of signalling and other electrical equipment.

Short take

Preventive healthcare is a national imperative

Sangita Reddy

We have 101 million diabetics, 315 million with hypertension, and a healthcare system that meets most of them only after the damage is done. This is not a future crisis. It is a present emergency.

Our clinical capabilities have advanced dramatically. We can detect risk earlier, intervene faster, and treat with precision that was unimaginable a generation ago. Yet, our collective behaviour remains largely unchanged. We continue to wait for illness to announce itself.

The finding, drawn from over 500,000 corporate health assessments in Apollo's Health of the Nation Report 2026, says 8 in 10 corporate employees are overweight. Nearly half had pre-diabetes or diabetes. Their mean age was 38.

This is the defining feature of India's health emergency: it is largely invisible until it is not. Non-communicable diseases accumulate in silence, across years of unexamined blood sugar, unchecked blood pressure, and unaddressed lifestyle risk. In surveyed rural populations, 99.8 per cent reported inadequate fruit and vegetable intake, 91.1 per cent were physically inactive, and roughly 83 per cent consumed excess dietary salt. These are not fixed characteristics of the Indian people

What we are witnessing is not a future crisis. It is a crisis already in motion.

What India needs now is a preventive healthcare mindset that moves from being advisory to becoming systemic. Screening must be continuous, not occasional. Health records must evolve into living, dynamic profiles that guide personalised interventions over time. And most importantly, individuals must be empowered to become active participants in their own health journey.

This is where integrated care models — combining clinical expertise, digital monitoring, and personalised pathways — can redefine outcomes.

We now have, for the first time, the tools to change this at scale. The Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission has created 73.98 crore ABHA health IDs and linked 49.06 crore health records — the structural foundation of what could become the world's largest longitudinal health database. Paired with AI-driven analytics, this infrastructure enables the identification of individuals at elevated risk of cardiovascular disease or specific cancers well before any symptoms appear.

The shift from episodic treatment to predictive, continuous, personalised care will not happen through a single policy announcement. It will happen through digital health records, community-level risk screening, and clinical protocols that treat prevention with the same rigour we have long reserved for cure.

A nation that chooses prevention chooses its own future.

The writer is Joint Managing Director – Apollo Hospitals

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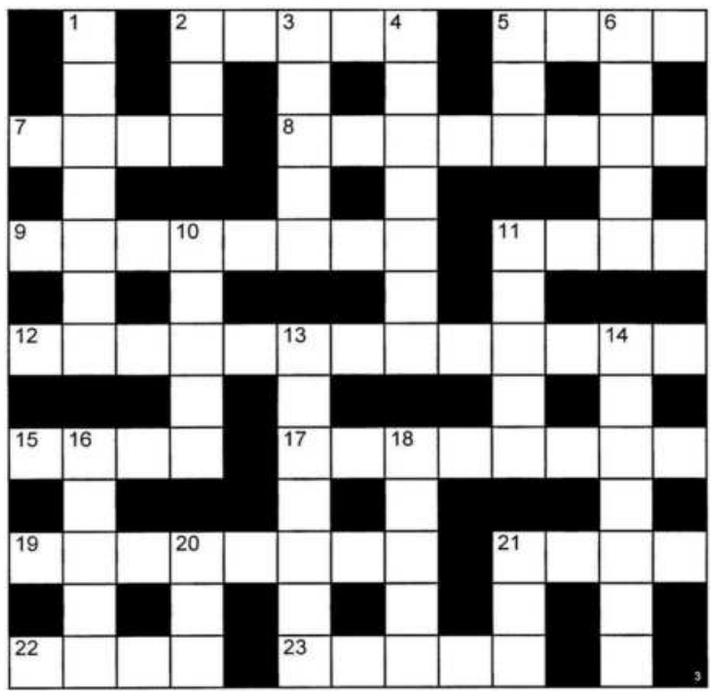

EASY

ACROSS
02. Ascent (5)
05. Do as told (4)
07. Leave out (4)
08. Unnecessary (8)
09. Hooked on to sea bed (8)
11. Fit (4)
12. Mentally ill (13)
15. Cards (4)
17. Dreadful (8)
19. Concerning art, refinement etc (8)
21. Allurement (4)
22. Show appreciation (4)
23. Respected church member (5)

DOWN
01. Supernatural, more than human (7)
02. Sever (3)
03. Target ring (5)
04. Distance across (7)
05. Night-bird (3)
06. Canvas support (5)
10. Cries a greeting (5)
11. Destroy, disable (5)
13. Watch (7)
14. Indication of tavern (3-4)
16. Unkind (5)
18. Lubricated (5)
20. Knock lightly (3)
21. Drinking-place (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS
02. Get up a tract, by the sound of it (5)
05. Follow instructions: that's nothing, to a Turkish governor! (4)
07. Don't put in for honour? It follows! (4)
08. It is superfluous to double the end of the sewing implements (8)
09. Can do her wrong, having got a hold on bed! (8)
11. It is not suffering, being a supplier of oil (4)
12. In two minds about chic little number: her zip's broken! (13)
15. Four from the pack that can't be returned to the server (4)
17. Causing offence can be electrifying (8)
19. How cruel to laud absence of ode, being concerned with arts (8)
21. It may entice one to be at the wicket and hold one (4)
22. Thunderous sound of hands getting together? (4)
23. Sambucus has lived a longer time (5)

DOWN
01. Other-worldly devil in charge (7)
02. Not the joint one would welcome in one's income (3)
03. More near the centre, this man is satisfied with a good meal (5)
04. The scope for being able to study in the bath after a loss (7)
05. A bird that might give voice to 'is displeasure (3)
06. Some support for a painter, as when surrounded by fish (5)
10. Gladly notes the arrival of one painter Frans took in (5)
11. Cause devastation of a part of the new reckoning (5)
13. Watch the late schoolfellow start the rally (7)
14. Picture a name that might prove popular with drinkers (3-4)
16. It is savage to be caught with the wrong lure (5)
18. Should move freely, if so intoxicated! (5)
20. The top Scottish bug attached to a telephone wire (3)
21. A piece of soap across which liquor may be served (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2690

ACROSS 1. Changing-room 8. Narrator 9. Stir 11. Ensue 12. Emptily 13. Vase 15. Zero 19. Noisome 20. Audio 22. Iris 23. Duration 24. Nightingales
DOWN 2. Harms 3. Neared 4. Ironed 5. Outside 6. Merry-go-round 7. Intervention 10. Spy 14. Sailing 16. Cog 17. Return 18. Banana 21. Drive

CHENNAI
businessline.
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ON THE CAMPAIGN TRAIL.

The past fortnight belonged to Parle's Melody, proving that diplomatic sweet-talking can do wonders for brand clout. It even overshadowed Bajaj group's outstanding AI-aided emotional storytelling film, which otherwise would have owned the news cycles.

Bapu and Bajaj

Bajaj group marked its centenary by releasing a deeply emotional commemorative fim, *Kathni Karni Ek Si*, using a combination of AI and immersive, imaginative storytelling. It cleverly uses a fictional return of Mahatma Gandhi, who, at founder Jamnalal Bajaj's urging, undertakes to audit modern Bajaj businesses, and meets up with present-day members of the family. From them, he learns about the group's authentic commitment to its ethical, Swadeshi roots. Conceptualised by Wondrlab, and directed by Rajkumar Hirani of the *Munnabhai* series fame, the film shows how human imagination paired with AI can further brand legacy in wonderful ways. Ambitious in scale, with appearances by the Bajaj leaders, it's a path-breaking film.

No 'shoo shaa'

Toing, Swiggy's affordable food delivery platform, launched its first brand film across digital channels, aimed at reiterating its "lowest price guarantee" proposition. The film, curated to appeal to Gen Z, brings a hilariously chaotic spectacle to life — it shows a wedding *baraat* in its full glory trying to squeeze through the narrow corridors of a building just to deliver food to a customer at her doorstep. While the on-screen chaos is entertaining, the message conveyed is clear — Toing consumers don't need all this "shoo shaa", nor do they have to pay extra! The film was conceptualised, written and directed by Swiggy's in-house team.

Road-tripping through NE

Swedish beauty and wellbeing company Oriflame took the road less travelled. Its just-concluded North-East Yatra was one of the most ambitious influencer-led brand campaigns undertaken in the region. Executed in partnership with Whosthat360, the initiative covered over 5,000 km, cutting a glowing trail across 13 cities through April and May, engaging more than 300 influencers and connecting with young women, creators and entrepreneurs across the region. At each location, participants became storytellers, sharing their experiences through reels, posts and word of mouth in their own languages and registers. This creator-first approach produced a wave of authentic, community-generated content that amplified the campaign far beyond its on-ground footprint, giving Oriflame a rare kind of earned visibility.

A serious matter

The new Redcliffe Labs campaign messaging is on point, calling attention to the tendency to ignore health symptoms until they become unmanageable. Yet, it falters a bit in execution as the sudden breaking out into a song is jarring. It stars cricketer Gautam Gambhir — chosen perhaps to create the punning message "*thoda gambhir ho jao*" — and shows a relatable situation of a person making light of his symptoms until confronted by the sudden appearance of Gambhir, who advises a lab test.

◉ PIONEER'S PATH

Sirona's Act II: Breaking more taboos

CATEGORY CREATOR. The femtech firm is transforming menstrual and intimate hygiene through innovations and education

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

It's been quite a rebound for Sirona Hygiene, the company that has launched several innovative women's wellness products in India. Sold to The Good Glamm group but acquired back last year by its founders, Deep and Mohit Bajaj, the company is firing on all cylinders in its second avatar, aiming for ₹500 crore annual recurring revenue (ARR) in 24-36 months.

Founded in 2015, Sirona launched with PeeBuddy, a portable female urination device that allows women to pee standing and thereby avoid contact with potentially unhygienic toilet surfaces, especially when travelling. The company then expanded into the manufacture of menstrual cups and a few other intimate hygiene products.

In 2022, The Good Glamm group infused ₹100 crore into the femtech company through primary and secondary investments, and went on to acquire it in 2024 in an all-cash ₹450-crore deal. Cut to 2025, the founders decided to buy back the company within four months of the completion of the deal as The Good Glamm group became mired in various challenges, including mounting losses.

Co-founder Deep Bajaj says the D2C firm, in its second avatar, will continue to focus on innovative products and solutions for unaddressed hygiene issues women face, right from puberty to menopause. The current portfolio includes menstrual cups, tampons, period panties, pH-balanced intimate care and toilet hygiene essentials.

FROM PUBERTY TO MENOPAUSE. Sirona's female wellness portfolio

THE CUP REVOLUTION

"We have now scaled up to about ₹100 crore ARR. I will be disappointed if we don't reach ₹500 crore revenue run rate in the next 24-36 months. If we had been running the business normally, we would have already been at ₹220-300 crore run rate. So, our focus is to recover it in one year, and then return to normal operations and scale up. We would love to be known for the cup revolution that we have built and have a significant share as the market grows," Bajaj says.

"In 2018, we may have sold about 1,000 menstrual cups, but in 2023 we were selling 8 lakh cups a year. Today, about 5 million women use our cups, moving away from sanitary pads forever. We came up with India's first herbal period pain relief patch and then launched the first natural anti-chafe cream for intimate areas for women."

The feminine hygiene space has been shifting beyond sanitary napkins, driven by urban consumers. The menstrual cup market is estimated to be about ₹100 crore, and Bajaj says Sirona has regained about 50 per cent market share on online channels after its relaunch.

"I believe the adoption of alternative period products in urban regions will accelerate significantly. Already challenger formats, such as menstrual cups, liners and period panties, have gained a 20-25 per cent share, and this shift will become more pronounced driven by millennials and Gen Z," he adds.

Menstrual cup, a ₹100-crore market

Deep and Mohit Bajaj, Co-founders of Sirona Hygiene

In a strategic expansion, the company recently decided to launch a specialised, menopause-focused everyday product range. "Menopause is one of the most underserved yet high-potential categories within women's healthcare. This launch is a natural extension to build a comprehensive women's wellness portfolio that supports every life stage," he says, describing how they are breaking taboos as they go along.

THE AWARENESS CURVE

Since Sirona's first innings, the market has evolved rapidly with the emergence of social media platforms that raise awareness about female hygiene needs and the proliferation of online shopping channels, which make products more accessible.

"Today, Gen Z buyers are far more empowered with access to information. At the same time, the emergence of e-commerce and quick commerce has changed the distribution landscape," Bajaj says. He expects a large chunk of online sales from quick commerce.

The company is also focusing on building a bigger offline presence in top cities, but in a calibrated manner and with an emphasis on modern trade and pharmacies, Bajaj says. "Nearly 15 per cent of our sales comes from offline, and modern trade contributes nearly 80 per cent. Once we scale up to a certain level, we will focus on general trade," he says.

VENDING MACHINES

Services are also part of the plan. The firm, for instance, has begun installing intimate product vending machines in public spaces, such as universities, malls and airports. "It is not a big revenue stream but, as a brand, we always put consumers first and we believe it gives them a lot of comfort," Bajaj says.

The vending machine has, in fact, sparked some questioning on social media. Is the Indian audience ready for it?

Naresh Gupta, Vo-founder and Managing Partner at Bang in the Middle, which did some early campaigns for Sirona, weighs in: "I absolutely think that the Indian audience is ready and the new younger audience has stopped seeing intimate products as either a taboo or a problem. The vending machine idea itself is not new but when placed in airports, it got Sirona more visibility than all its earlier placements."

He adds, "Sirona has always been brave, it has always broken the category codes. And it does this in a very matter-of-fact way, in a tone that is factual but sensitive."

Back in the hands of its founders, this menstrual disruptor will be watched closely for its next wave of transformations.

Prices are going up, so let's buy lots more!

An inflationary environment creates some surprising impacts on consumer behaviour

THE CURIOUS MARKETER

HARISH BHAT

In India, and many other parts of the world, we are faced with an inflationary environment, driven by significant increases in oil prices, supply chain bottlenecks and a volatile geopolitical situation. As inflation bites deep into wallets, we will witness changes in consumer behaviour.

Some of these changes are what we expect based on conventional economic theory.

For instance, middle-class consumers will tighten their belts and focus spending on essential items, such as food, apparel and education. They will spend far less on discretionary items, such as expensive vacations or purchasing fancy new furniture. Consumers are also likely to trade down to less expensive brands in many categories, and will hunt more actively for special offers. At the top end of the market, affluent customers may continue to spend without too much anxiety.

However, inflation also has counter-intuitive effects on consumer spending. Here are some such impacts, which marketers would do well to bear in mind.

ACCELERATED SPENDING

If consumers anticipate that prices of essential products will continue to increase in the future, they are likely to stock up to beat future price increases. For essential products such as rice or cooking oil, consumers may double or even triple the inventory at home.

BIG-PACK SPENDING

Conventional wisdom says consumers will buy less during inflation, and downgrade to smaller packs, particularly in FMCG categories. However, if they see that large packs offer better value, then many may go for them. Similarly, bundled offers are perceived as excellent value when overall budgets are under pressure.

IN-HOME SPENDING

Many consumers will address rising costs by cutting discretionary spends, such as eating out in fine-dine restaurants. However, they will still wish to eat well, and may step up the quality of groceries and foods they buy for their home. The thinking would be, "We cannot afford to eat at a fancy restaurant for some time, so why not prepare and eat better dishes at home, even if the ingredients are more expensive?"

HOW MUCH? As prices climb, shoppers tighten purse strings ISTOCK

LIPSTICK EFFECT

As consumers reduce large discretionary spends (such as vacations), they will actively seek smaller purchases that can make them feel as good (such as a lipstick or a lovely new dress). The fundamental human need to feel happy will continue to drive many purchases.

FESTIVAL EFFECT

Tightening belts for most part of the year will also lead to a desire to break out and splurge, at least for small periods of time. Such pent-up demand will usually express itself most sharply during festivals such as Puja and Diwali.

'MADE IN INDIA' EFFECT

There appears to be a perception that the current inflation is driven by the increased cost of imported products such as oil, and exacerbated by the depreciating rupee. This may see consumers gravitating towards "Made in India" products, driven by three factors — economy in immediate purchase, a desire to curb further import-driven inflation, and an overall feeling of patriotism.

HEALTH EFFECT

As consumers see that inflation also impacts the cost of healthcare, anxieties over keeping good health may rise further, especially among middle-class and upper middle-class consumers.

It could lead to prioritising the purchase of products that contribute to good health — for example, local fruits and protein-rich lentils.

Overall, an inflationary environment provides marketers unique opportunities to cater to specific consumer needs.

This is also a time of vulnerability for consumers, and brands can win their trust by behaving responsibly.

Harish Bhat is an avid marketer and bestselling author

◉ INFLUENCER ECONOMY

'The ASCI report is an uncomfortable but necessary reading'

Chitra Narayanan

The creator economy could absolutely become a multi trillion-dollar category over time, feels Raj Mishra, Group CEO of QYOU Media, the company that owns Chtrbox, the first pure-play influencer marketing company to list on the Indian stock exchange (in October 2025). Mishra, former country head of TikTok India (he was also its employee No. 1), says globally the creator economy market (this encompasses influencer marketing, content creation, platform payouts, and so on) is estimated at about $250 billion. The company went in for an IPO since it perceived the industry to be at an inflection point. Given how Unilever recently announced it was shifting 50 per cent of its ad budget to social media and influencer marketing, the IPO proved to be a good call for Chtrbox, which manages 104 creators through Chatterbox Represent. The influencer marketing firm's results, posted on May 29, show a 42 per cent increase in operational revenue to ₹84.22 crore in FY26 from ₹59.12 crore in 2025, and a net profit of ₹9.2 crore.

Excerpts from two separate conversations with Mishra:

What prompted the IPO?

It was about validating the creator economy as a serious investable sector in India. India is one of the fastest growing creative markets in the world. We have 80-100 million creators today. But monetisation per creator is still kind of a fraction of the global benchmark. So the gap between scale and monetisation is where the opportunity really lies for me and the company. The space has largely been fragmented and unstructured. Being public brings in some discipline, transparency and long-term thinking.

The latest ASCI report on annual complaints mentions the spread of misleading ads on digital media, especially through influencers, and how this makes identification difficult. How can the industry fix this?

The ASCI report is an uncomfortable but necessary reading. A 21 per cent surge in cases, 97.3 per cent of violations on digital platforms, and 1,609 influencer ads flagged, with nearly all requiring modification... this isn't a compliance blip. It's a structural failure.

The core problem is the 'speed-first, compliance-later' culture of digital advertising. By the time a violation is flagged and taken down, the content has already reached millions through creator networks, affiliate chains and messaging groups. Post-publication correction is not a compliance strategy, it's damage control.

Fixing this requires three things. First, compliance must move upstream, and claims must be vetted before content goes live, not after. Second, influencer onboarding must include compliance literacy as standard. The fact that 76 per cent of India's top creators have been flagged tells us this is an education problem, not just an intent problem. Third, technology needs to do the heavy lifting — AI-powered, real-time content scanning is the only way to operate at the scale and speed the digital ecosystem demands.

Raj Mishra, MD and CEO, Chtrbox; and Director, QYOU Media

The advertiser community, too, cannot absolve itself. Restricted-category brands don't place illegal ads without demand-side enablers. Accountability must run across the entire chain — brands, intermediaries and platforms alike.

Brands are demanding formal revenue targets from influencer campaigns. Has this led to rate rationalisation?

The shift to performance-linked influencer marketing is real, significant and, yes, it has created friction. When a creator who has built his or her rate card on follower count is suddenly asked to justify fees against conversion data and cannot, the relationship breaks down. We're seeing this particularly with mid-to-large creators who haven't yet built the commerce infrastructure — affiliate links, shoppable content, conversion funnels — that performance briefs now demand.

But rate rationalisation is more nuanced than a blanket correction. What's actually happening is a market bifurcation. Creators who can demonstrate clear revenue impact are commanding higher fees than ever. Those who relied on vanity metrics are facing compression. The market is simply repricing influence on the basis of proof.

For platforms like Chtrbox, this shift is largely healthy — it forces rigour into campaign design and elevates the category. But there's a real risk of overcorrection. Influencer content shapes consideration, builds brand preference and drives discovery well before the point of purchase. Forcing everything into a last-click attribution model will systematically undervalue that contribution. The smarter brands are moving toward blended measurement — combining platform data, lift studies and CRM (customer relationship management) signals. That's where the industry needs to go collectively.

Performance accountability and short-termism are not the same thing. The best influencer partnerships are long-form and brand-building. Reducing every campaign to a cost-per-acquisition target may improve quarterly attribution numbers but risks eroding the brand equity that made those conversions possible.

How are AI influencers doing? Are more brands using them?

AI influencers are definitely emerging. But as someone who's seen the industry from day zero, I would say AI influencers will never replace human creators. They're expanding what's possible in the creator economy. But the authenticity and community factor that a real creator brings cannot come from an AI creator.

What we can do as a company is have a mix of AI-led storytelling opportunities, so brands can affordably create content that is snackable and good to look at. But, at the same time, we want to be cognisant of how the human influencers are also being positioned.

FROM THE LABS.

Ship test tank at IIT-Madras

You are building a new ship or submarine. Computer simulations can predict how it may behave in water. But simulations alone are not enough. Aircraft manufacturers test their designs in wind tunnels. Can something similar be done for ships?

Yes. IIT-Madras is planning such a facility at its satellite campus in Thaiyur, near Chennai.

Called HYDRA Centre, it will feature a half-km 'towing tank'. Scaled-down ship and submarine models will be dragged through the water channel under controlled conditions, allowing scientists to study resistance, stability, wave patterns, propulsion efficiency and manoeuvrability.

When completed, HYDRA could become a key national facility for testing and refining indigenous ship and submarine designs, strengthening India's self-reliance in advanced maritime and naval engineering. The centre is expected to support advanced work on warships, submarines and underwater platforms.

MDL'S SUPPORT

Public sector Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited is supporting the initiative. The company has funded several related research facilities at IIT-Madras through its corporate social responsibility programme.

One of these is a newly inaugurated 'circulating water tunnel', which is closely related to the HYDRA concept. While HYDRA studies how moving vessels behave in water, the circulating water tunnel examines how flowing water behaves around stationary objects. In this facility, built at a cost of ₹4.5 crore, water is continuously circulated past test objects such as propellers, offshore platforms, bridge pillars and underwater structures. Engineers use it to study turbulence, drag and complex flow behaviour around these "bluff bodies" — objects with broad or blunt shapes that disturb water flow significantly.

Another proposed collaboration between IIT-Madras and MDL relates to "high-efficiency multi-stage thermoelectric sub-zero refrigeration systems" for submarines and small naval vessels. Put simply, the idea is to develop compact, quiet and highly reliable cooling systems for defence platforms.

Submarines require specialised cooling for electronics, sensors, storage systems and crew environments. Conventional refrigeration systems rely on compressors and moving mechanical parts. Thermoelectric refrigeration, instead, uses semiconductor devices that produce cooling when electricity passes through them — a phenomenon known as the Peltier effect. "Multi-stage" systems stack together multiple cooling stages to achieve very low temperatures.

Internship at battery recycler

NavPrakriti, a lithium-ion battery recycling and refurbishment company based in eastern India, has signed a memorandum of understanding with IIT-Kharagpur for joint research, skill development and technology advancement in the battery recycling sector.

The tie-up will focus on battery material recovery and hydrometallurgical refining and extraction technologies for critical minerals, such as cobalt, nickel and lithium.

Students from IIT-Kharagpur will intern and train at NavPrakriti's facilities, including its Serampore plant. They will gain exposure to industrial-scale battery recycling and refurbishment operations.

The joint research projects, technological consulting assignments and capacity-building initiatives are aimed at developing skilled manpower for the emerging battery and critical minerals ecosystem.

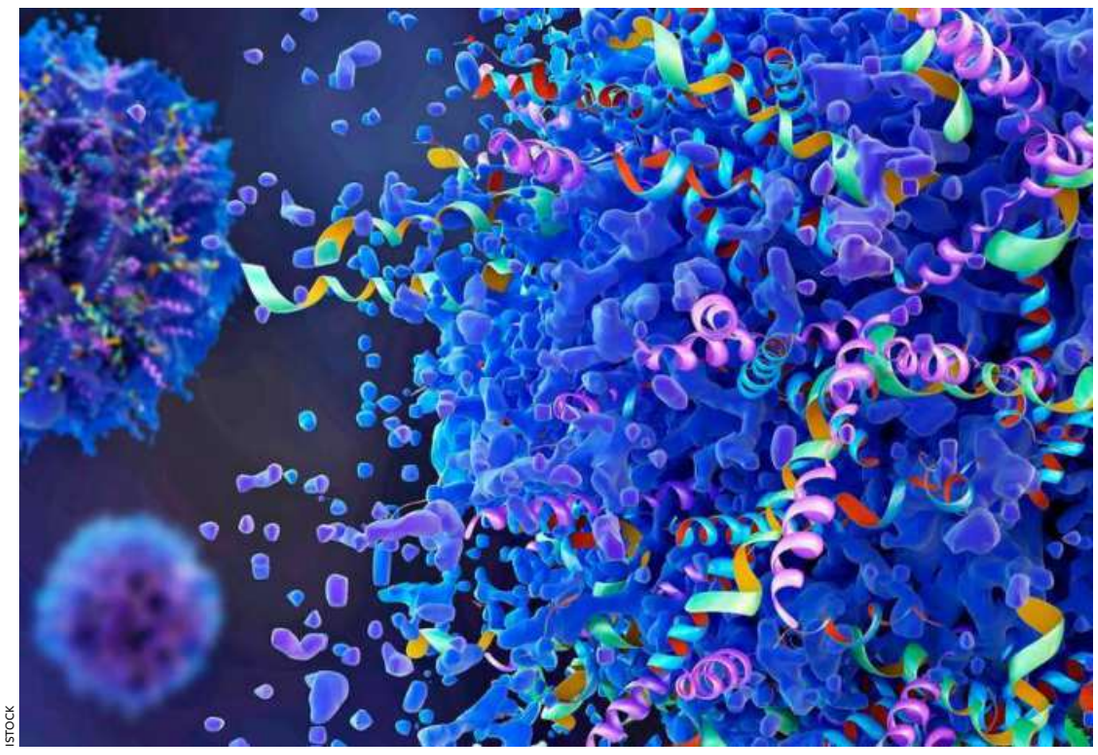
NavPrakriti said it has been recognised under the National Critical Mineral Mission for extraction of cobalt, nickel and lithium.

◉ **DRUG DISCOVERY**

The protein-peptide bonds that heal

JOINT ENDEAVOUR. Researchers at IIT-Bombay engineer stapled peptides to aid in the fight against cancer and other diseases

K Bharat Kumar



ISTOCK

Peptide-based drug discovery has gained currency in the past decade. This branch of pharmaceuticals promises solutions to tricky health issues such as cancer. Now, two researchers from IIT-Bombay and one from the Technical University of Darmstadt, Germany, have reported work that suggests ways to improve peptide-based drug discovery.

Inside every living cell, thousands of proteins constantly interact with one another, switching genes on and off, repairing damage, carrying signals and deciding whether a cell should live or die. Many diseases, including cancer, arise when some of these protein–protein interactions go wrong.

One such interaction involves two proteins called p53 and MDM2. Normally these two proteins function together in a checks-and-balance manner. The p53 protein is a sort of sentinel — it triggers the destruction of cells that have gone bad, such as with cancer. Excess of p53 can be a problem. MDM2 comes in and suppresses p53. This is fine but sometimes p53 is less or MDM2 is more; when this happens, MDM2 prevents p53 — the guardian angel — from doing its job. Keeping track of such happenings in cells has given rise to the study of 'protein-protein interaction'.

PRECISE STAPLING

Scientists have discovered that stapled peptides (*see box*) can bind themselves to MDM2 and prevent it from suppressing p53. This is because scientists have engineered the stapled peptides to resemble p53, and MDM2 attaches to them. This leaves p53 free to do its job, without hindrance from MDM2.

Drug discovery is about making the right kind of stapled peptide.

In a paper, the three researchers have used computer simulations to demonstrate that medical researchers should look not just at protein combinations but also the behaviour of the molecules in the solvent in which the proteins are immersed. In their study, the researchers focused on the behaviour of water molecules — the solvent — in the presence of stapled peptides.

They found that stapled peptides also altered the behaviour of water molecules. When a stapled peptide binds to its target protein, the water molecules gain 'entropy' or freedom, while the peptide itself becomes more stable and rigid. The behaviour of the water molecules could be manipulated to create more effective and 'stickier' medicines. Put simply, this means medicines (stapled peptides) can be made more effective by controlling how a drug interacts with the water molecules rather than by focusing only on the drug molecules' shape and binding capability.

A more stable peptide binds better with its target — its efficacy increases. "Peptide-based drug discovery is an emerging field... Using in-silico (computer-based) approaches, effective peptide drug candidates can be identified and filtered at early stages. However, the detailed thermodynamics at the binding interface are often overlooked," the researchers say in a joint statement to *businessline*.

They point out that in many ongoing drug discovery pipelines, the 'entropic effects' (freedom of movement of molecules) are largely ignored.

THERAPEUTIC PATHWAY

If a peptide's binding property is improved, will it translate into a drug that requires lower doses or has fewer side effects?

"Stronger binding affinity can provide several practical advantages, including lower therapeutic doses, reduced off-target effects and potentially lower treatment costs. Importantly, understanding how stapling affects both peptide structure and surrounding water dynamics provides a... basis for the rational design of more effective peptide therapeutics," the researchers respond in their statement.

However, they caution that translating the computational insights into clinical applications calls for more extensive experimental and clinical validation.

Interestingly, research into stapled peptides could well open the door to improved treatment for other diseases. "Researchers can identify optimal stapling positions and cross-linker chemistries that enhance binding affinity. This strategy expands opportunities for targeting challenging protein-protein interactions in areas such as oncology and immunology," the statement says.

PROTEINS AND PEPTIDES

- Peptides are short chains of amino acids. In a sense, they are "dwarf proteins".
- Most people know proteins as body-building molecules — which is true — but there are thousands of different proteins. For example, snake venom is a cocktail of proteins, as is haemoglobin.
- Both peptides and proteins are chains of amino acids. An amino acid is a molecule that has carbon, hydrogen, nitrogen, oxygen and a 'side chain' of molecules with other elements like sulphur. Since there are about 20 'side chains', there are as many amino acids.
- Stapled peptides are two peptides linked by a chemical. They are, therefore, engineered molecules.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
quantum@thehindu.co.in

◉ **WOW.** How plants summon help

Team Quantum

Most plants may not have the ability to ward off predators on their own, but they are not exactly defenceless either. It has long been known that plants under attack release volatile chemicals that summon the predators of their predators — like wasps that prey on leaf-eating worms.

Scientists are still divided over whether plants can "think" or consciously "cry for help". But now, researchers say they have understood the mechanism by which at least one type of plant — beans — sends out distress signals. When a caterpillar is munching on a leaf, chemicals in its spit activate a receptor protein called inceptin in the plant, setting off a herbivore-specific immune response. Bean growers using pesticides may not have noticed this natural defence .

Researchers became intrigued by high wasp activity in certain bean fields in Oaxaca, Mexico. They grew bean plants under three different conditions — leaves cut with a razor blade and dabbed with water, leaves treated with caterpillar oral secretions and leaves coated with inceptin. Dead caterpillars were pinned to all the plants.

The wasps largely ignored the razor-cut plants, suggesting leaf damage was not enough to trigger a distress signal. But plants treated with caterpillar secretions or inceptin drew more wasps.

"These findings provide a definitive molecular-to-ecological link... how a single immune receptor mediates ecologically relevant plant-insect-predator interactions in nature," the report says, adding it could pave the way for pesticide-free methods of crop protection.

◉ **ARTIFICIAL INFO-DUMP**

Fishing out fake news using a deep-learning neural network

Team Quantum

Researchers at the ABV-Indian Institute of Information Technology (IIIT), Gwalior, have developed a new artificial intelligence system that combines text analysis, image recognition and fuzzy logic to detect fake news in Indian media with high accuracy.

The system, called F2IND-IT! (fuzzy fake Indian news detection using images and text), was described in a recent paper uploaded to arXiv. The researchers say the project addresses a growing challenge in India, where rapid internet penetration and social media use have accelerated the spread of misinformation.

According to data from the Press Information Bureau, under the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, 1,575 fake news cases were reported between 2022 and March 2025. The number rose from 338 in 2022 to 583 in 2024. Data from the National Crime Records Bureau also show a 214 per cent increase in fake news cases during the early pandemic period from 2018 to 2020. A 2024 study by ISB and CyberPeace found that 46 per cent of false information was about politics, and over 77 per cent of it spread through social media platforms. Another survey among Gen Z users in Delhi found that 91 per cent believe fake news can affect election outcomes.

To tackle the problem, the researchers designed a multimodal AI model that analyses both the written content of news articles and the accompanying images. The framework uses DistilBERT — a lightweight language-processing model — to understand text semantics, while a convolutional neural network (ResNet-50), which is a deep-learning image recognition system, extracts visual features from photographs. These inputs are then combined using an 'attention mechanism' and processed through an adaptive neuro-fuzzy inference system (ANFIS), which produces a probability score indicating whether a news item is fake or genuine.

The model was trained and tested on the Indian Fake News Dataset (IFND), which contains more than 56,000 news articles spanning politics, elections, Covid-19, violence and other topics. According to the paper, the proposed system achieved an accuracy of nearly 98 per cent, outperforming several alternative model configurations in ablation studies.

The researchers say future versions could rely less on manually designed fuzzy rules and instead use data-driven systems capable of dynamically generating their own inference structures during training.

◉ **EARTH OBSERVATION.**

Indian Institute of Technology, Kanpur, hosts India's first DORIS beacon

Global network of DORIS ground stations is crucial for accurate satellite data collection

M Ramesh

The setting up of India's first DORIS ground beacon at the Indian Institute of Technology, Kanpur, is an important but somewhat under-the-radar step in India's space and earth observation capabilities. DORIS, short for 'Doppler orbitography and radio-positioning integrated by satellite', is a French system that tracks satellites and ground stations with centimetre-level accuracy.

The beacon at IIT-Kanpur is part of a global network of DORIS ground stations. Satellites carrying DORIS receivers use signals transmitted from these beacons to calculate their own position precisely. Because a satellite moves very fast overhead, the frequency of the signal changes slightly due to the Doppler effect — the same effect that makes a passing train's horn sound different as it moves away. By measuring these tiny frequency shifts from beacons around the world, the satellite can calculate its exact position and speed.

This accuracy is crucial for missions involving ocean altimetry, climate studies, mapping the earth's gravity field, monitoring sea-level rise and glacier movement, tracking tectonic shifts and precise satellite orbit determination.

A satellite measuring ocean height, for instance, may detect just a few millimetres of change per year. That measurement becomes meaningful only when scientists can know the satellite's orbit with centimetre-level accuracy. Otherwise, they cannot tell whether the ocean rose or whether the satellite drifted slightly. DORIS helps remove that uncertainty.

The system has been used in major international satellite missions, such as Jason, Sentinel, CryoSat and the Indo-French SARAL/AltiKa. Systems like GPS, VLBI (radio astronomy timing), laser ranging and DORIS together form the backbone of modern earth measurement.

BENEFITS FOR INDIA

The beacon at IIT-Kanpur strengthens India's role in global space geodesy — the science of precisely measuring the earth's shape, rotation and gravitational behaviour — and deepens Indo-French cooperation in the space sector. "The establishment of the DORIS beacon in India enhances the national geodetic infrastructure and participation in the global geodetic community," says Prof Onkar Dikshit of IIT-Kanpur.

"It will help establish a highly accurate and stable national terrestrial reference framework for surveying, mapping, infrastructure development, satellite navigation, disaster management, smart city planning and other strategic applications," he says.

ELITE NETWORK. The DORIS ground station at IIT-Kanpur

In addition, the Indian subcontinent is tectonically active due to the interaction between the Indian and Eurasian plates, making continuous geodetic monitoring critically important for understanding crustal deformation, intraplate tectonics, land subsidence, uplift and seismic hazards, he says.

Accurate geodetic monitoring can aid urban subsidence assessment in rapidly growing cities, improve floodplain mapping and enhance coastal vulnerability assessments in regions affected by sea-level rise and cyclones. The data products derived from DORIS-supported satellite missions can contribute to precision agriculture, water resource management, glacier monitoring in the Himalayas and early warning systems for natural hazards, such as earthquakes, landslides and floods.

Enhanced satellite orbit determination improves the quality of remote sensing products used in weather forecasting, environment monitoring, fisheries management and maritime navigation, directly benefiting societal planning and sustainable development initiatives.

Beyond national applications, the DORIS station strengthens India's contribution to international Earth observation and climate research programmes.

The inclusion of India in the global DORIS network fills an important geographic gap in the international space geodetic observing system and enhances the robustness of global reference frame realisation.

By hosting such advanced geodetic infrastructure, IIT-Kanpur positions India as an active contributor to the global space geodesy community while simultaneously advancing indigenous capabilities in satellite geodesy, precise positioning and earth system science.

HOW IIT-KANPUR GOT IN

In 2022, the International DORIS Service (IDS) announced a global call for proposals to establish a DORIS station. The proposal submitted by IIT-Kanpur was evaluated by the IDS Selection Committee against several technical and scientific criteria. These included network coverage and tectonic plate contribution, co-location with other geodetic instruments, antenna environment, monument stability, maintenance and security provisions, host institution capability and prospects for scientific collaboration.

One of the major strengths of the IIT-Kanpur proposal was its strategic location on the northern part of the Indian tectonic plate, addressing a significant gap in the current DORIS network. At present, the only DORIS station on the Indian plate is the Male station in the Maldives, while the Everest station lies near the Indian–Eurasian plate boundary.

The DORIS station at the National Centre for Geodesy (NCG) in IIT-Kanpur will provide improved spatial coverage for monitoring inter-plate and intra-plate tectonic deformation across the Indian region.

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - JUNE 1 - 2026

NEWS SNIPPETS.

Shipbuilder SHM Group launches high-speed aluminium passenger craft

The 140-year-old SHM Group, which is involved in shipbuilding, ship management and maritime safety services, has launched *Ocean Crewzer 8* (Y-410) at its Mumbai shipyard. Built entirely with aluminium, *Ocean Crewzer 8* is a 29-m high-speed passenger craft, designed to meet the requirements of waterway operations in India. Aluminium is an extensively preferred material for fast passenger vessels due to its light weight and higher fuel efficiency compared with standard steel ships. The launch of *Ocean Crewzer 8* is part of the SHM Group's continuous shipbuilding programme, which is focused on vessels catering to the rising maritime requirements of India, says a company release.

Speed delivery to offshore rigs

Hyderabad-based deep-tech startup BluJ Aerospace has developed a high-speed, autonomous vertical take-off and landing (VTOL) aircraft to airlift payloads directly from mainland warehouses to offshore oil and gas rigs

Source: BluJ Aerospace

RE POSTS.

Strengthening inland waterways logistics!
Cargo vessel Trishul, along with two barges carrying 1500 MT of cement belonging to Star Cement, has commenced its voyage from Pandu to Patna. The movement highlights the growing role of inland waterways in enabling efficient, sustainable and cost-effective cargo transportation across the country.

Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways
@shipmin_india

A simple prank with a laser can have serious, life-threatening consequences. Pointing a #laser at an aircraft is a serious #offence and endangers pilots, passengers, and everyone on the ground. Report any incidents/offence to help keep our skies safe

Chennai (MAA) Airport
@aaichnairport

@NHAI_Official has finalized a tentative list of National Highway stretches proposed for monetization under the Toll-Operate-Transfer (TOT) and Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvIT) modes during the Financial Year 2026–27. However, the list does not include the assets proposed to be monetized through Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust (RIIT) for FY 2026–27.
The identified #NationalHighways assets with a total combined length of 1692.5 km comprise of stretches across nine states including Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and Maharashtra. These Highway assets collectively represent economic and logistics corridors with established traffic potential and robust connectivity significance

PIB India
@PIB_India

Truck rental rates

Rentals for 18-tonne payload

Truck route	Rentals as on		% change
	May 14	May 28	
Delhi-Mumbai-Delhi	1,74,000	1,73,000	-0.58
Delhi-Nagpur-Delhi	1,57,000	1,56,000	-0.64
Delhi-Kolkata-Delhi	1,75,000	1,76,000	0.57
Delhi-Guwahati-Delhi	1,95,000	1,94,000	-0.52
Delhi-Hyderabad-Delhi	1,99,000	2,00,000	0.50
Delhi-Chennai-Delhi	2,17,000	2,15,000	-0.93
Delhi-Bengaluru-Delhi	2,20,000	2,21,000	0.45
Delhi-Ranchi-Delhi	1,66,000	1,65,000	-0.61
Delhi–Raipur-Delhi	1,63,000	1,62,000	-0.62
Delhi-Kandla-Delhi	1,39,000	1,40,000	0.71
Mumbai-Chennai-Mumbai	1,71,000	1,72,000	0.58
Ludhiana-Hyderabad-Ludhiana	1,99,000	2,00,000	0.50
Mumbai-Kolkata-Mumbai	1,99,000	1,97,000	-1.02
Chennai-Ahmedabad-Chennai	2,12,000	2,11,000	-0.47
Bengaluru-Kolkata-Bengaluru	2,13,000	2,15,000	0.93
Bengaluru-Mumbai-Bengaluru	1,42,000	1,44,000	1.39
Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram-Delhi	2,80,000	2,83,000	1.06
Guwahati-Mumbai-Guwahati	2,82,000	2,83,000	0.35
Nagpur-Chennai-Nagpur	1,62,000	1,63,000	0.61
Kolkata-Guwahati-Kolkata	1,52,000	1,55,000	1.94
Indore-Delhi-Indore	1,45,000	1,46,000	0.68
Ahmedabad-Indore-Ahmedabad	99,000	1,00,000	1.00
Vijayawada-Mumbai-Vijayawada	1,63,000	1,62,000	-0.62
Vijayawada-Kolkata-Vijayawada	1,52,000	1,54,000	1.30
Mumbai-Nagpur-Mumbai	1,12,000	1,13,000	0.88
Mumbai-Pune-Mumbai	64,000	65,000	1.54
Mumbai-Aurangabad-Mumbai	82,000	83,000	1.20
Mumbai-Nashik-Mumbai	64,000	65,000	1.54

Figures in ₹ Source: Subham Freight Carriers India Pvt Ltd

STRATEGIC GATEWAY

Mumbai port's future-ready focus

STRONG MIX. With JNPA cornering cargo, Mumbai port pitches itself as a specialised bulk, liquid and coastal shipping hub

G Naga Sridhar

Mumbai Port Authority is charting a new course in India's maritime waters by building a distinct and future-ready ecosystem, says its Chairperson, M Angamuthu.

Instead of competing with container-focused Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA), he tells *businessline* that Mumbai port is positioning itself as a unique port-city gateway that blends cargo logistics, coastal connectivity, world-class cruise infrastructure, waterfront redevelopment, green initiatives and high-value services — all of it from its strategic location in the heart of India's most globally connected commercial hub.

Edited excerpts:

FLOWING FREIGHT. Mumbai port leads in liquid bulk cargo handling

M Angamuthu, Chairperson, Mumbai Port Authority

Mumbai port has historically lost cargo share to JNPA. What is the long-term strategy to remain commercially relevant?

Mumbai Port Authority and JNPA are complementary national maritime assets, rather than rivals. Mumbai port has sharpened its focus on segments in which it holds clear leadership. Today, it is India's leading liquid bulk cargo port, with 15.5 per cent national market share, and the largest handler of exim iron and steel cargo, at 35 per cent. It also has a strong presence in project cargo, automobile exports, bunkering, ship repair, coastal shipping and maritime services. The port is positioning itself as a specialised bulk, liquid and coastal shipping hub, aligned with India's Maritime Vision 2047.

What is the current cargo mix and which segments are driving growth?

FY26 was the best year in Mumbai port's history, with cargo throughput of 75.15 million tonnes (MT), accounting for 8.22 per cent of traffic among India's major ports.

Liquid bulk cargo — crude oil, petroleum products, chemicals and LPG — remained the backbone of operations. Coastal shipping strengthened further with a 10.48 per cent share, supported by the Sagarmala programme. Automobile exports touched 80,986 units, while project cargo, fertilizers, agri-commodities and break-bulk cargo emerged as important growth segments.

What is your cargo target for FY27?

The cargo targeted is around 80 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) for FY27, implying 6.4 per cent growth over FY26, with a medium-term target of 85 MT by FY28. Growth is expected from higher liquid bulk traffic, anchorage cargo, project imports and automobile exports driven by OEM partnerships. Operational reforms, including O&M (operation and maintenance) contracts for 22 berths at Indira dock, are expected to improve productivity and vessel turnaround time.

Tankage expansion, OCT (offshore container terminal) berth utilisation, digital documentation and smart gate operations are expected to support growth. The India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and rising coastal shipping demand are likely to strengthen Mumbai port's strategic position.

What investments have been planned for the next three to five years?

Focused on cargo expansion over the next two to three years, Mumbai port plans ₹15,000–18,000 crore investment in mechanisation and sustainable infrastructure. Major projects include the ₹800-crore sixth oil berth at Jawahar Dweep, which will add 22 MTPA capacity, along with crude tankage investment of about ₹3,000 crore by HPCL and ₹1,000 crore by BPCL. At Pir Pau, a new 2 MTPA fourth chemical berth and additional tankage are being developed. The port is also modernising 22 berths at Indira dock through private sector-led mechanisation.

Waterfront projects include the ₹877-crore international marina and the broader ₹22,672-crore eastern waterfront redevelopment programme, which includes a proposed ₹5,500-crore convention centre. Investments are also being made in anchorage expansion, logistics connectivity, digital systems, green tugs, shore power and desalination infrastructure.

How strong is Mumbai port's financial position?

The port closed FY26 with operating income of about ₹2,806 crore and total income of ₹3,319 crore. It generated an operating surplus of nearly ₹1,731 crore, reflecting strong cash generation and financial stability. The port maintained a cost per tonne of about ₹143 and an operating ratio of 38.31 per cent, indicating disciplined expenditure management and operational efficiency.

How much land is earmarked for redevelopment and monetisation?

Of the nearly 956-hectare holding along Mumbai's 10-km eastern waterfront, around 253 hectares have been identified for redevelopment, including 193 hectares for public infrastructure such as promenades, roads, gardens and heritage spaces. The remaining 60 hectares are earmarked for commercial and mixed-use development. Separate projects have been planned at Princes' dock and the Indira dock marina. The New Sewri warehouse, supported by Atal Setu connectivity, is being evaluated for monetisation through lease or PPP model.

How will Vadhvan port impact Mumbai port?

Vadhvan port is being developed as a major container hub linked to IMEC and the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC), giving it strategic geopolitical importance. Mumbai port believes Vadhvan will complement, rather than compete with it.

Since Mumbai port exited container operations decades ago, there is limited overlap in cargo segments. Vadhvan's focus will remain on containers, while Mumbai port will continue to focus on liquids, bulk cargo, coastal shipping and waterfront development.

India's total port throughput is projected to rise from about 855 MT to over 2,000 MT by 2047, creating enough demand for multiple major ports in Maharashtra. Mumbai port also expects Vadhvan to reduce the infrastructure pressure on western Maharashtra and generate feeder and hinterland opportunities to benefit the wider Mumbai Metropolitan Region.

We value your feedback.
Do send your comments to
bl.logistics@thehindu.co.in

SUPPLY RESILIENCE

From sea lanes to store shelves

R SATHYANARAYANAN

The ancient Tamil adage "*Thennai maraththil thel kottinaal, panai maraththil neri kattum*" (when a scorpion stings a coconut tree, a swelling appears on a palmyra tree) aptly captures the interconnected nature of events. The supply chain disruptions roiling a large part of the world today exemplify this.

Diet Coke, sold only in aluminium cans, is feeling the pinch in India. The Strait of Hormuz blockade has prevented the cans from reaching Indian factories, affecting production and supply. Ditto several alcoholic and other non-alcoholic beverage brands dependent on overseas supply of can-grade aluminium.

This is not the first time a supply disruption has affected brands on shelves. In 2024, during the Red Sea crisis, Tesla and Volvo reportedly halted production in Europe due to delays in component deliveries.

The Black Sea blockade in 2022 affected the supply of semiconductor-grade neon gas, critical in chip manufacturing.

A literal blockade occurred in 2021 when a container vessel remained stuck in the Suez Canal route for six days.

History shows that such trade disruptions push economies to search for alternatives — new routes and even new industries. The fall of Constantinople in the 15th century disrupted the old Asia-Europe trade route and was one of the reasons that forced European powers to look for new sea routes to India and beyond in the East. Centuries later, Napoleon Bonaparte's blockade of British trade led to sugar shortages in Europe, prompting the development of beet sugar as a substitute.

STOCK TAKING. Agile logistics help keep shortages away ISTOCK

GLOBAL LESSONS

In today's globalised world, there are useful lessons in how some companies prepared for, or responded to such shocks.

When the 2011 massive earthquake in Japan disrupted the supply lines of Toyota, the automobile giant mapped 6,800 critical components and their choke points across suppliers, as part of its RESCUE (REinforce Supply Chain Under Emergency) system.

Another key decision was to maintain buffer stocks for non-substitutable parts such as semiconductor chips, for which the just-in-time rule may not be applicable. This system kept Toyota afloat even during the Covid-19 lockdowns when other automobile companies suffered. These scenarios echo the ideas set out in the 2004 paper by Martin Christopher and Helen Peck on resilient supply chains, warning that excessive lean practices increase risk and advocating buffer stocks for critical components.

Nokia offers a classic case of supply-chain recovery. In 2000, a fire accident damaged inventory and disrupted the "clean room" operations at the Royal Philips electronics plant in New Mexico, which supplied semiconductor chips to Nokia and Ericsson.

A Nokia supply manager noted the drop in inbound stock levels and alerted the organisation. When Philips said recovery would take about a week, Nokia started tracking the inventory of five critical components daily, instead of once a week. After knowing that full recovery at Philips would take several weeks, impacting the production of nearly four million handsets, the Nokia team quickly moved to source three components from new suppliers in the US and Japan, and expanded the inventory from the Philips plants in the Netherlands and China.

Nokia's lightning response was honed on lessons learned from an earlier disruption in 1995.

Ericsson, on the other hand, lacked similar agility in information flow and was forced to postpone critical new product launches, resulting in heavy loss of revenue and brand visibility.

Globally, companies are working on strategies such as vertical integration, supply base diversification, agile logistics, end-to-end supply chain mapping and modelling, and product redesign and R&D to better prepare for supply disruptions.

Coca-Cola, the manufacturer of Diet Coke, is reportedly banking on "format flexibility" to tide over the current crisis — it is moving from aluminium cans to glass bottles in a limited way to avoid a market supply crunch during the peak summer season.

BUILDING SAFEGUARDS

It is imperative for businesses to continuously study risks such as blockades to build short- and medium-term resilience.

Managers need not wait until shelves empty out to diagnose the risk. Two questions can reveal much of the danger. Can we replace it, make it, pack it or ship it another way? And will customers notice or care if we cannot? When both answers are unfavourable, a supply-chain disruption quickly becomes a brand crisis.

In an interconnected world, supply-chain resilience is not only an operations capability but also a marketing safeguard.

The writer is Sundram Fasteners Associate Professor of Marketing, IFMR Graduate School of Business at Krea University

E-SAFE HARBOURS

Digitised trade exposes ports to cyber attacks

ISTOCK

T E Raja Simhan

Ports handle nearly 80 per cent of global trade by volume and have evolved into far more than just physical gateways for ships and cargo. Modern ports now operate as highly digital ecosystems where port authorities, terminal operators, customs agencies, shipping lines and logistics providers rely on shared electronic platforms and real-time data exchange.

While digitisation has improved efficiency and transparency, it has also exposed ports to growing cyber risks. A cyberattack today can disrupt cargo movement, halt vessel operations, disable critical equipment and create ripple effects across supply chains and national economies.

These dangers are highlighted in the World Bank report, *Cybersecurity in ports: Shifting from risk to resilience*. Based on a global survey of more than 100 port stakeholders, expert interviews and extensive research, the report identifies major policy, operational and capacity gaps, particularly in low- and middle-income countries.

The study found a significant cyber resilience gap between advanced economies and developing regions. Ports in high-income countries showed better incident reporting systems, regular cybersecurity training and more frequent risk assessments.

In contrast, ports in many developing countries continue to face shortages in technical expertise, outdated systems and weak cyber preparedness.

The report stresses that cybersecurity in ports is now inseparable from operational resilience.

As ports adopt 'Port 4.0' technologies and integrate information technology (IT) with operational technology (OT), cyber incidents can affect not just office systems but also vessel movements, cargo handling and automated equipment, such as robotic cranes and guided vehicles.

The financial impact is also growing. The average cost of a cyber incident in the maritime transport sector reached $5,50,000 in 2023, thrice that in 2022, while average ransom demands stood at $3.2 million.

The World Bank says improving cybersecurity does not necessarily require entirely new institutional structures. Ports already have operational risk management systems, vendor oversight mechanisms and business continuity plans that can be adapted to include cybersecurity.

The report recommends establishing clear cybersecurity frameworks, updated inventories of physical and digital assets, regular risk assessments and testing of recovery plans through drills and simulations.

MY FIVE.

ANUJ MATHUR
Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, Canara HSBC Life Insurance

Morning walks, home food and no devices at dinner time

1 **Clear mind:** As an early riser, my day starts at 5 am. I value the stillness before the city wakes up. Quiet hours give me thinking space to clear emails, reflect on key meetings and set priorities. It helps begin the day with clarity rather than rush.

2 **Walking:** By 6.30-7 am, I am out for my morning walk. Staying active has become a small daily ritual I rarely skip. It lifts my energy and gives me a moment to reset both physically and mentally.

3 **Home food:** I prefer simple, home-cooked meals and consciously avoid outside food. I believe food should be nourishing and sustainable rather than indulgent. Eating clean keeps my energy steady through long workdays and reinforces the discipline I try to bring in other areas of life.

4 **Consistency:** I have never believed in extreme regimes. For me, health is about consistency. Along with my daily walks, I prioritise adequate sleep. Rest is essential as it's what allows me to stay sharp and balanced.

5 **No devices:** Evenings are about switching off. Dinner with family, unhurried conversations, and no devices around the table... these help me decompress. We occasionally watch *MasterChef* together (a shared favourite) before I catch up on the day's headlines and call it a night.

CAPSULE.

FDA norms on animal testing

The US Food and Drug Administration has issued a draft guide to reduce animal testing in non-clinical safety assessments for certain cancer drugs.

"This draft guidance fulfils the agency's promise to reduce the use of animal testing during drug development," said FDA's Oncology Center of Excellence Director Angelo de Claro. "With recommendations for eliminating unnecessary animal testing, using a single relevant species instead of two or replacing animal studies with evidence-based approaches... the FDA is advancing a more efficient drug development process."

When finalised, the guide will provide recommendations for general toxicology studies, including when animal testing may be unnecessary because there is no binding or pharmacologic activity. In some cases, the guidance recommends using rodent studies only or replacing three-month non-human primate studies with a weight-of-evidence risk assessment, which may include new approach methodologies. The FDA has called for public comments by July 30.

COMING UP.

Humanity in every drop

Every year on June 14, the world marks World Blood Donor Day — a global tribute to millions of blood donors whose generosity saves lives every day. Their contribution is essential to health systems everywhere, supporting patients during emergencies, childbirth, surgeries, cancer treatment and the lifelong care of many serious conditions. This year's campaign — 'One drop of humanity. Give blood. Save lives' — places humanity at the heart of blood donation. It reminds us that each donation is a powerful expression of solidarity, compassion and collective responsibility.

◉ COMFORT VS CONTROL

E-pharmacies: The missing regulatory prescription

NO TURF WAR. Concerns include deep discounts, online prescriptions and distribution margins

PT Jyothi Datta

ISTOCK

The neighbourhood chemists recently downed shutters for a day, responding to a call from an apex association representing local pharmacists. They were protesting against the presence of online pharmacies and the "predatory" practices that threatened the livelihoods of retail chemists, the association said.

While some see the offline-online chemist standoff as a turf war, the issue has been festering for at least 10 years now — reinforcing the need for a long overdue regulatory framework.

It's one thing to sell garments or electronics online, but quite another selling life-saving medicines from such platforms, caution multiple voices from the retail trade. Doctors red-flag a system where some fellow doctors give online prescriptions, calling attention to a multi-layered healthcare issue in dire need of a regulatory resolution.

Offline chemist stores are governed by the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, among other laws, and mandated to abide by rules on matters ranging from storing and dispensing of medicines to margins offered to distributors. No deep discounts are possible, say chemists, contrasting this with the offers on online channels.

In its white paper on online pharmacies, the Indian Medical Association recognises that they may offer convenience, but at a price. There are "no well-defined dedicated laws for online pharmacies", the IMA observes, outlining concerns on storage, distribution, potential misuse of habit-forming medicines and data privacy (use of scanned prescriptions). IMA former President RV Asokan says the sanctity of the prescription is lost. There are laws covering online consultation — what can and cannot be done, he says, but not so with online pharmacies. Doctors aligned to these organisations issue online prescriptions, but what if the patient's condition has worsened or they need a different medicine, he asks.

A 2018 notification governing online pharmacies has lapsed, raising questions on the very legitimacy of e-pharmacies, industry insiders point out, as the issue passes through multiple courts. Some online pharmacy representatives explain that they are a "marketplace" — supplying medicines from legitimate chemists, on doctor prescriptions and through safe delivery practices.

'HIGHER STANDARDS'

Countering the contentious issues raised, Rahul Guha, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of digital healthcare platform API Holdings, the parent company of online pharmacy PharmEasy, says, "PharmEasy is a platform that directs the order to retail chemists who, by the way, are fully compliant with the Drugs and Cosmetics Act... (we) have a higher standard of compliance because nothing is dispensed without a prescription. Everything is ABDM (Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission) integrated... there is no risk to the patient." Stating that online players follow distribution rules like offline chemists, he points out that retail chemists, too, deliver medicines home.

Further, organisations like his offer a "value proposition" to the customer in terms of multiple services (diagnostics, doctor consultation and so on), which a standalone chemist may not be able to offer, he says. As for online prescriptions, he clarifies that the doctors are registered practitioners and issue prescriptions under their name, and do so with responsibility. Other representatives at online pharmacies did not respond or declined to comment on the issues raised.

PREDATORY PRICING

Representing over 12 lakh chemists, the All India Organisation of Chemists and Druggists (AIOCD), which called the recent day-long strike, has long demanded "a level-playing field". "Large corporate entities are disturbing market balance through deep discounting. While margins on essential medicines are fixed by the government, these entities are creating unfair competition. This is threatening the survival of small chemists in rural and semi-urban areas, which will ultimately destroy the accessible medicine supply system," the AIOCD said in submissions to authorities, including the Prime Minister.

REGULATORY AMBIGUITIES

Dr Sujit Paul, Group CEO, Zota Healthcare — the parent of generic drugs pharmacy DavaIndia — underlines the need for a physical "hyperlocal" store. A pharmacy or anything related to medicines is "sensitive", he says, and cannot have a "warehouse model" like an apparel business. (DavaIndia has offline and online presence.)

A warehouse model must have more checks built in to ensure the right medicine is sold. There are regulatory ambiguities, and hence the repeated stand-offs, he explains.

Paul questions whether companies dealing with medicines have a "bandwith" in healthcare. "It is not (a) grocery business. There are ways to handle medicines." A marketplace means an aggregator model, which works with electronic gadgets, "you don't risk your health for that," he says, questioning the sourcing, storage and distribution.

◉ **PALM-TOP PHARMACY**

In the fray: 1mg (bought by Tatas); NetMeds (Reliance); Amazon; Flipkart; PharmEasy; Apollo Pharmacy; Zepto and Blinkit.
The online pharmacy market is estimated at ₹12,000 crore

Source: Industry data

◉ FROM THE REGULATOR

South Africa cracks down on illegal weight-loss drugs

The South African Health Products Regulatory Authority (SAHPRA), in collaboration with the South African Pharmacy Council (SAPC), has intensified its enforcement action against the unlawful manufacturing, promotion and distribution of unregistered GLP-1 and GIP medicines containing either semaglutide, tirzepatide or a combination of both for weight loss.

A joint inspection at iDexis (Pty) Ltd, trading as Sentra Pharmacy (Pretoria), found critical regulatory non-compliance, and all the GIP/GLP-1 injectable products found on site were seized.

The investigation revealed that the company was producing and supplying medicines under the guise of "compounding", but it was outside the legal framework. While compounding is strictly limited to the preparation of medicines for individual patients based on a valid prescription, the facility was found to be manufacturing and marketing GIP/GLP-1-based products, including semaglutide, tirzepatide and combination formulations, for broader commercial distribution, particularly for weight management.

Further inspection unearthed serious deficiencies in quality, safety and regulatory compliance. These included the illegal import of semaglutide and tirzepatide active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs), absence of analytical testing to confirm identity, potency and purity, and inadequate sterile manufacturing conditions, high risk of contamination and inadequate equipment for aseptic medical preparations, among others.

The room allocated for producing GLP-1/GIP products didn't meet the requirements of aseptically prepared products. In addition, no pharmacovigilance system was in place to monitor or respond to adverse drug reactions. SAHPRA also noted the reports of adverse events, including hospitalisations, linked to the use of these products, as well as concerns regarding possible illegal import of APIs and promotional activities targeting healthcare providers and consumers.

The company has been instructed to initiate a full recall of the affected products.

Source: SAHPRA

LENS ON HEALTH

BEARING UP. Aquilina (89), who has respiratory problems, drinks water next to her husband, Antonio (90), as they sit on a bench in the shade on Passeig de Sant Joan during a spring heatwave in Barcelona, Spain REUTERS

Why it's time to revise the list of essential medicines

RIGHT TO HEALTH. The primary health centres serving rural populations are mandated to stock listed essential medicines NAGARA GOPAL

BY INVITATION

SRISHTI BHATT

India's national list of essential medicines (NLEM) plays a major role in ensuring access and affordability in India. It serves as a guide for the procurement of medicines that are available free of cost in public health facilities. However, the potential of the NLEM is often not realised due to the stockouts reported in public health facilities and loopholes in the Drugs Prices Control Order (DPCO). Moreover, many new and efficacious medicines are missing in the list.

A regularly updated NLEM will directly benefit patients across India. First, and most important, as the medicines on the NLEM are subject to price control through the National Pharmaceuticals Pricing Authority, they are accessible to households that cannot afford the market rates. Second, when doctors prescribe from an evidence-based essential medicines list, patients receive treatments that are proven to work, reducing needless drug use. Third, as a guiding document for the procurement and supply of medicines in the public sector, the NLEM is a lifeline for rural communities and the urban poor who depend on public health facilities.

The NLEM mandates that listed medicines must be stocked at all levels of the public health system, including the basic primary health centres that serve rural populations.

GLOBAL COVENANT

The Supreme Court of India has consistently held, through a series of landmark judgments, that the right to life enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution includes the right to health and the right to access medical treatment; the non-revision of the NLEM is, therefore, a potential violation of the fundamental right to life. India is party to the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR), under which a core obligation is the provisioning of essential medicines "as from time to time defined under the WHO Action Programme on Essential Drugs".

The World Health Organization's model list of essential medicines serves as the basis for India's NLEM. The WHO has revised its model list on two occasions since 2022 — in 2023 and 2025 — incorporating significant additions and updates.

In stark contrast, India's NLEM has not been revised since 2022. While the NLEM contains 384 medicines, the WHO model list of 2025 contains 523 medicines. Around 17 active cancer treating agents, four supportive agents for cancer treatment and nine monoclonal antibodies (mAbs) from the WHO model list are missing in the NLEM. This means the list that determines which medicines citizens can access affordably is falling behind global standards. Every medicine absent from the NLEM is one that escapes price control, remaining beyond the reach of millions of ordinary Indians, particularly the rural poor.

The case for updating the NLEM is overwhelming and urgent. India cannot continue to be the "pharmacy of the world" while leaving its own people with a medicine list that lags years behind global standards.

The writer is an independent legal researcher. Views are personal

How PMOS pushed this student to grow her own food

Kolkata resident embarked on hydroponic farming in a quest for chemical-free, nutrient-rich produce

Richa Mishra

It was an attempt to deal with her health issues that led Vansika Jhawar, a student of Kalinga Institute of Industrial Technology, to develop a low-cost, vertical micro-farm for year-round, chemical-free food production, with minimal water and energy input. Added to that, it was designed for homes, remote areas and disaster zones.

Kolkata-based 22-year-old Jhawar explains that her venture, Annapurna, tackles multiple crises at one go — shrinking farmland, water scarcity and unreliable climate — to produce chemical-free food.

It all started when she was diagnosed with polycystic ovarian disease (PCOD), or polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome (PMOS), as it is now called, some years ago. Her doctor's concern was whether it was triggered by the chemically treated food being consumed, she says.

FRESH START. Vansika Jhawar, student and hydroponic farmer

"Even though we assume the food we get is fresh, it often contains growth hormones, pesticides and fertilizers. That made me realise that accessing truly fresh food is a big challenge today. I got the idea to grow food close to us and keep it as chemical-free as possible. I started exploring hydroponic farming," she says.

COMPLEX DISORDER

PCOD was recently renamed PMOS after multiple global medical organisations agreed that the name should reflect "the complex, long-term hormonal or endocrine disorder", as opposed to being just about 'cysts' and ovaries, according to the Endocrine Society. The society was among more than 50 patient and professional organisations that jointly came up with the new name.

PMOS is diagnosed in countless women, and medical recommendations include a lifestyle change focused on a healthy diet — high-protein, low-carbohydrate foods and avoiding processed sugars.

NUTRIENT QUALITY

Jhawar overcame challenges related to funding, space and approvals to build her own prototype set-up for hydroponic farming, using waste material such as leftover pipes from construction sites.

"My initial investment was almost zero. I only spent a little on hydroponic solutions and seeds," she says.

"Leafy greens are the easiest to grow and can be harvested within 2–3 weeks... so that's my starting point. Later, I may move to more profitable crops like saffron," she says. "I got my first harvest tested in labs for nutrient quality. The results were good. In fact, research shows hydroponic produce can sometimes be even more nutrient-rich than traditional farming," she adds.

◉ **WHAT IS PMOS?**

Polyendocrine metabolic ovarian syndrome — earlier known as polycystic ovarian disease (PCOD) — impacts one in eight, or more than 170 million women worldwide.
It is characterised by fluctuations in hormones impacting weight, metabolic and mental health, skin and the reproductive system.

Source: Endocrine Society

CHENNAI
businessline.
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QUICKLY.

Stablecoin demand may soon fade: BoE's Greene

Dubrovnik: The popularity of stablecoins could soon fade, replaced by tokenised deposits, or digital versions of traditional bank deposits, said Bank of England policymaker Megan Greene (*in picture*) on Sunday. Stablecoins, which are crypto assets designed to maintain a stable value, have grown in popularity in recent years and a further rise is still expected by some after issuance levelled off in recent months. REUTERS

Akeso's lung cancer drug helps patients live longer

Bengaluru: An experimental drug developed by China-based Akeso helped patients with advanced squamous non-small cell lung cancer live 15 per cent longer than BeOneMedicines' immunotherapy Tevimbra and cut the risk of death by over one-third in a study presented at a medical meeting on Sunday. Patients who received Ivonescimab and chemotherapy lived an average of 27.9 months, compared with 23.7 months for those who received Tevimbra and chemotherapy. REUTERS

J&J drug reduces risk of prostate cancer spread

Johnson & Johnson's prostate cancer drug Erleada used with hormone-blocking therapy six months before and after prostate surgery improved the chances of eliminating the cancer and reduced the risk of disease progression or death, according to data from a late-stage trial presented on Sunday. The study found that those who received the regimen were nine times more likely to have little to no detectable cancer in the prostate at the time of surgery compared with those given testosterone-blocking therapy alone. REUTERS

EV 2-W registrations up 58% in May amid fuel supply woes

NEW ORDER. TVS retains top position followed by Bajaj; Ather, Hero gain, Ola loses share

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The electric two-wheeler (E2W) market maintained its strong growth trajectory in May 2026, with total registrations rising 58 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to 1.64 lakh units from 1.04 lakh units in the same month last year, according to Vahan portal registration data as of 8.30 am on Sunday.

Accelerating consumer adoption of electric mobility — aided by expanding product portfolios, improving charging infrastructure and rising participation from both legacy automakers and dedicated EV manufacturers — along with a larger push towards energy security post the West Asia war led to the surge.

WEST ASIA FACTOR

On a sequential basis, too, EV two-wheeler sales grew 18 per cent compared to total registrations of 1.39 lakh units in April 2026, indicating sustained demand for electric scooters and motorcycles across the country.

Going electric

Company	May 2025	Market share (%)	May 2026	Market share (%)
TVS Motor Company	25,804	25	41,489	25
Bajaj Auto	22,642	22	38,005	23
Ather Energy	14,016	13	27,523	17
Hero Motocorp	7,381	7	18,253	11
Ola Electric	18,967	18	14,752	9

Source: Data collated from Vahan website on May 31, 2026 at 8.30 am *(in units)*

Poonam Upadhyay, Director, Crisil Ratings, said the average monthly run rate through the first half of FY26 was around 1.05 lakh units.

"Three factors are driving growth. Fuel supply concerns stemming from the West Asia conflict has added to consumer anxiety around petrol dependence, nudging more buyers towards electric. The running cost advantage remains a compelling pull — operating costs are significantly lower than comparable ICE options, a gap that only widens as fuel price uncertainty persists. Legacy manufacturers with established distribution and service networks continue to gain ground, giving buyers confidence that after-sales support is no longer a concern," she said. The underlying demand drivers — improving cost economics, fleet adoption and wider OEM participation — continue to be drivers, she added.

LEADERS & LOSERS

TVS Motor Company retained its leadership position in the segment, registering 41,489 units during May and holding on to a 25 per cent market share.

The company recorded a 61 per cent increase over the 25,804 units sold in May 2025.

Bajaj Auto consolidated its second position with registrations rising 68 per cent to 38,005 units from 22,642 units a year ago. Its market share edged up to 23 per cent from 22 per cent, reflecting increasing acceptance of its electric scooter range.

Among the new-age players, Ather Energy had a standout month, nearly doubling its registrations to 27,523 units from 14,016 units in May 2025, a 96 per cent y-o-y growth. The Bengaluru-based EV maker expanded its market share to 17 per cent from 13 per cent, emerging as one of the biggest gainers.

Hero MotoCorp also delivered a strong performance, with registrations more than doubling to 18,253 units from 7,381 units a year earlier. Its market share climbed to 11 per cent from 7 per cent, highlighting the company's growing presence in the electric mobility space.

However, Ola Electric continued to face pressure amid intensifying competition and its own execution challenges. Registrations fell to 14,752 units in May 2026 from 18,967 units in the corresponding month last year. Its market share nearly halved to 9 per cent from 18 per cent.

MPC may keep repo rate on hold

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Upside risks to inflation and downside risks to growth amid the West Asia conflict may prompt the RBI's rate setting panel to hold the policy repo rate at its upcoming meeting.

The risks to inflation and growth stem from a spike in global fuel and commodity prices, supply chain disruptions, financial market volatility, weather-related disruptions and a depreciating rupee.

The RBI, on its part, may revise the retail inflation projection upward and GDP growth projection downward and announce some measures to support the rupee, said economists.

The Monetary Policy Committee's (MPC) second meeting of FY27 is scheduled from June 3 to 5. The repo rate, which was last cut in December 2025 from 5.5 per cent to 5.25 per cent, was left unchanged at the MPC's last two meetings — in February and April 2026.

The SBI's economists, in a report, observed that going by the growth-inflation spiral, they expect the CPI trajectory (as of now) may indicate more than 5 per cent inflation for the next three quarters (current quarter at 4 to 4.1 per cent). Further,

The Monetary Policy Committee's second meeting of FY27 is scheduled from June 3 to 5 REUTERS

FY27 CPI inflation projection is currently at 5 per cent with risks tilted to upside, though well under the RBI's target range.

"We expect Q4 FY26 real GDP growth of closer to 7.2 per cent and FY26 GDP growth is likely to be at 7.5 per cent. Our nowcast full year FY27 GDP growth rate is at 6.6 per cent. However, with continued geopolitical uncertainties, the numbers will be revised as more data comes in. Our call is along 'hold the rates' with a data-driven future dependency," they said.

NEUTRAL PAUSE

Barclays economists Aastha Gudwani and Amruta Ghare expect the MPC to persist with a neutral pause in June, looking through supply shock-driven higher inflation, using the flexibility that an inflation targeting mandate offers.

Manoranjan Sharma, Chief Economist, Infomerics Ratings, said the decision at the June 2026 policy review meeting is expected to be a "pause with caution", relying more on forex and liquidity tools than immediate rate hikes.

"A modest downgrade of 20-30 bps is expected in the growth forecast due to higher energy costs, softer external demand and tighter financial conditions. However, resilient domestic demand may limit the extent of cuts. The RBI may raise retail inflation projection by 30-50 bps as imported inflation risks from crude and rupee weakness intensify. Food inflation remains critical, while sustained oil prices could revive core inflation pressures," Sharma said.

TO DEFEND RUPEE

SBI economists noted that despite strong macro fundamentals, the rupee is depreciating much more vis-à-vis other currencies. Therefore, there is a need for augmented intervention by the RBI.

Also, forex reserves are optimally sufficient to combat the unidirectional slide of rupee, while aiming to curb excess/undesired volatility concomitantly as the prime aim.

New Chief of Defence Staff, Navy Staff chief join office

Our Bureau
New Delhi

General NS Raja Subramani, after taking charge as the Chief of Defence Staff on Sunday, said his primary focus would be towards transforming the armed forces and ushering in reforms ensuring the theaterisation of command.

He also promised to accelerate the development, induction and integration of indigenous weapon systems into the armed forces.

Gen Subramani took over as the country's senior-most military commander from General Anil Chauhan,

(from left) General NS Raja Subramani, Chief of Defence Staff, and Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, Chief of Naval Staff ANI

whose desire to roll out the theaterisation of command during his tenure remained unfulfilled.

Prior to this, Gen Subramani served as the Military Advisor at the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS) following retirement as the Vice Chief of Army Staff on July 31, 2025.

GLOBAL INSECURITIES

He occupies the post of CDS at a time when global insecurities have become the new normal and the tri-services are undergoing reforms — from integration to technology absorption to keeping up with modern warfare challenges.

In his illustrious career spanning over 40 years, Gen Subramani, acknowledged as an expert on China and Pakistan, served across a wide spectrum of conflict and terrain profiles and held a host of command, staff and instructional appointments.

'HIGHEST HONOUR'

Admiral Krishna Swaminathan also assumed charge as the 27th Chief of the Naval Staff on Sunday, taking over from Admiral Dinesh Kumar Tripathi, who superannuated after 41 years of service.

Admiral Swaminathan said, "Being selected by the top leadership of the country for this job has been the highest honour and privilege of my life. Indian Navy stands vigilant to protect national interests wherever they are and is very actively deployed in a regional security environment that continues to remain challenging, complex, unpredictable and uncertain."

He noted that indigenous defence manufacturing will remain a key result area during his tenure.

"The Navy is deeply committed to jointness, Aatmanirbharata and indigenisation," he added.

'Over 600 State bills passed in 2025 with limited scrutiny'

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The latest PRS report on *Annual Review of State Laws 2025* reveals a disturbing trend of State Assemblies rushing through over 600 bills in 365 days of 2025, displaying a lack of severe legislative oversight over issues critical to democracy and government functioning. Instead of threadbare debates and discussions on legislation, many Assemblies have turned into rubber stamps, data compiled by the report in May 2026 suggested.

As many as 30 per cent of the bills were passed on the day they were introduced, with the Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Gujarat, Jharkhand, Mizoram, Puducherry and Punjab Assemblies passing all legislation either on the day of introduction or the next. States that passed a higher number of bills often did so in a single sitting. Karnataka passed 17 bills in one sitting and 12 in another, while Assam passed 14 bills in a single sitting, flagged the PRS report.

Even though State legislatures passing over 600 bills in 2025 is worrisome, the number of legislation being cleared is on the rise. Notably, in 2024, the Assemblies had cleared a total of about 500 bills. Karnataka had passed the highest number of bills at 84 in 34 sitting days, followed by Assam at 60 bills in 21 sitting days.

NUMBER OF SESSIONS

The number of legislative sessions held in Vidhan Sabhas and Vidhan Parishads have also seen a sharp decline. State Assemblies met for an average of just 24 days in 2025, pointed out the report. It, however, marked a

marginal increase from 21 days in 2024 and 23 days in 2023. Of the average 24 days of Assemblies conducting businesses, in Nagaland, it met only for seven days. This stood at 43 days for Odisha.

Some States have set minimum targets for annual sitting days, either through legislation or the rules governing their procedures. Barring Himachal Pradesh, no State has met its prescribed target.

The Constitution requires no more than passage of six months between two sittings of a State Assembly. The report also stated that all States met this requirement in 2025. In several cases, this was achieved with the States meeting just enough to meet the requirement.

For example, Assam convened a one-day session in June, between March and November sessions. Gujarat, after adjourning in March, met for three days in September. In Rajasthan, the gap between two sessions was five months and eight days, while in Meghalaya, the interval was five months and 26 days.

Most sittings occur in the first quarter of the year when the States meet to discuss and pass their budget.

Deep tech start-up Impensus raises ₹1.6 cr in pre Series A

Our Bureau
Chennai

Impensus Electronics Private Ltd, a deep-tech start-up incubated at IIT-Madras Research Park, has raised ₹1.6 crore in its Pre-Series A round, with participation from angel investors affiliated with Keiretsu Forum Chennai Chapter and IN44 Capital.

Founded by Guru Vignesh V and Dinesh Narayanan, Impensus has developed a controlled environment technology platform that monitors and regulates ethylene concentrations, temperature, humidity and other parameters within enclosed ripening and storage chambers. Essentially, the system helps extend the shelf life of perishable produce, reduce their spoilage and standardise ripening outcomes. The company currently focuses on banana, mango, apple and specialised edible mushrooms. Its commercial partnerships include BigBasket, Paiyur Group and other leading distributors, and quick commerce companies such as Hyperpure and Zepto.

The start-up plans to use the capital towards scaling commercial operations, product development and regulatory approvals for its solutions that help reduce post-harvest losses in the agricultural supply chain.

Its proprietary capability to actively control ethylene — the plant hormone that governs the ripening process — alongside a broader set of microclimate variables, gives it a distinct edge, said the company.

Impensus has received institutional backing from MeitY, channelled through the Crescent Innovation and Incubation Council.

Used luxury EVs, ICE SUVs command near-new prices

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Prices of pre-owned luxury EVs such as the BMW i7, Mercedes-Benz EQS and Audi e-tron are rising sharply in the used luxury vehicle market, while top-end ICE SUVs such as the Defender, G-Wagon and Mercedes-Maybach continue to command near-new valuations amid tightening supply, rising replacement costs and resilient premium demand.

Used luxury EV resale values have rebounded from recent lows as improving buyer confidence, tighter supply and repeated OEM price hikes reshape residual-value dynamics across the premium automotive market.

"Prices should ideally have fallen further after the new year, but instead they have started moving up," said Jatin Ahuja, Founder of luxury used-car platform Big Boy Toyz (BBT). "This trend

MORE ROOM. Mass-premium EVs like the Mini Cooper SE are still correcting sharply in the secondary market KARUNAKARAN M

has only started becoming visible in the last 15-30 days."

BBT clarified that the luxury EV and premium ICE market is not witnessing appreciation over original invoice prices, but rather a recovery in secondary-market valuations after an initial steep correction phase in luxury EVs and continued supply tightness in high-demand ICE segments.

Industry executives say the improving residual-value trend is now becoming visible across flagship luxury EVs in the secondary market.

A 2024 BMW i7 that had corrected to ₹1.25–1.30 crore late last year is now seeing stronger resale movement at around ₹1.45 crore. Two-year-old Mercedes-Benz EQS models, trading around ₹75 lakh earlier, are moving closer to ₹85 lakh. Audi e-trons that had corrected to ₹65–68 lakh are now witnessing stronger resale movement at ₹75–78 lakh.

PRICE CORRECTION

Demand for pre-owned luxury SUVs, such as the Land Rover Defender, Range Rover, Mercedes-Benz GLS, G-Wagon and Maybach, has remained exceptionally strong.

"A one-year-old Defender still sells at almost 90 per cent of its value," Ahuja said.

Dealers say a Mercedes-AMG G63 with an original on-road price of about ₹4.2 crore is still commanding ₹3.5–3.7 crore in the resale market because of immediate-delivery premiums and limited availability.

Entry-level luxury ICE vehicles such as older BMW 320d models continue to witness steep traditional depreciation, while mass-premium EVs such as the Mini Cooper SE are still correcting sharply in the secondary market.

Industry executives say the strongest recovery is currently concentrated in flagship luxury EVs such as the BMW i7, Mercedes EQS and Audi e-tron, while top-end ICE SUVs continue to benefit from scarcity economics and immediate-delivery premiums.

On a lone crusade to save Chinar trees in the Valley

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

When Abdul Ahad Khan recently planted a batch of Chinar saplings on the premises of a temple in North Kashmir's Lalpora village, he crossed a remarkable milestone — 1,500 Chinar trees planted. The 42-year-old resident of Nagri Malpora in the frontier district of Kupwara begins his day early, tending to and watering the Chinar saplings he has planted over the years across villages in the district.

DROP IN COUNT

"The number of Chinar trees in the Valley are on a decline. I wanted to plant as many trees as I can in my life," said Khan. Locally known as Bouyn, the number of maple trees in Kashmir has witnessed a significant decline over the decades. From an estimated 42,000 in the 1970s, their count is now believed to be between 32,000 and 33,000.

Experts attribute the decline to factors such as urban expansion, unauthorised felling and changing climatic conditions. To strengthen conservation efforts, the Jammu and Kashmir Forest Department, in collaboration with the J&K Forest Research Institute (JKFRI), launched an initiative in 2021 to digitally register heritage Chinar trees across the region.

Thousand of trees were assigned unique identification numbers, enabling the authorities to monitor, document and protect these iconic trees.

Abdul Ahad Khan

DAILY SOLO SOJOURN

For Khan, the mission to save Chinar trees is deeply personal. Unmarried and living a modest life as a labourer, he said the trees have become his family. "I did not marry. These Chinar trees are my family and my legacy," said Khan. "Whatever I earn through labour, I spend a part of it on planting and caring for these trees. Seeing a sapling grow into a tree gives me immense satisfaction." He said he often travels long distances to plant saplings in schools, temples and public spaces.

Despite limited financial means, he remains committed to expanding the green cover and inspiring others to take up conservation efforts.

"My dream is to leave behind 50,000 Chinar trees for future generations," he said. "A little financial help from the government could make things easier for me," Khan added.

Taj debuts in Frankfurt as IHCL expands its footprint

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Indian Hotels Company Ltd (IHCL) will open a Taj hotel in Frankfurt this week, strengthening its overseas footprint.

The 134-key Taj Hessischer Hof Hotel in Frankfurt is IHCL's first in continental Europe and its 25th international hotel overall. Thirteen other properties are in the pipeline in Bahrain, Bhutan, Egypt, Nepal, South Africa, Sri Lanka and the United Arab Emirates.

Over 85 per cent of IHCL's revenue comes from its domestic business, but the chain is keen to expand overseas with its luxury Taj brand using an asset-light model.

International expansion with the iconic Taj brand remains an important strategic pillar for IHCL and reflects the growing global relevance of Indian hospitality, said its Managing Director and CEO Puneet Chhatwal.

In January, IHCL opened Taj Gangtey Resort and Spa in Bhutan, and last week it launched the six-key Taj Bush Lodge in Kruger National Park in South Africa.

In September 2023, IHCL had announced the signing of its Frankfurt hotel on an operating lease model. The hotel was built in 1952 on a former city palace site owned and operated by the Prince of Hesse.

SIGNS OF RECOVERY

Germany is among the most visited destinations in Europe, but it showed weaker growth in overnight stays compared to Spain, Italy and France. The absence of big-ticket events in 2025 is cited as a reason for the muted performance.

Average daily rates of hotels in Germany declined 2.4 per cent to €107.11 between January and April on a year-on-year basis, according to CoStar, a global provider of real estate data. In the case of Frankfurt hotels, the average daily rate was up 0.5 per cent to €113.74 in the same period, it said.

There are signs of recovery as international arrivals in Germany increased 2.7 per cent in early 2026, said the European Travel Commission in May.

Chhatwal said, "Frankfurt remains one of Europe's leading financial and commercial centres with strong demand across corporate travel, MICE (meetings, incentives, exhibitions and conferences) and international business communities."